

Ezra-Nehemiah: A Commentary

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Dedicated to Jon Rice, tutee in Hebrew and tutor in being a follower of Christ

Preface

The English-speaking world is accustomed to speaking of a certain pair of biblical books known as “Ezra” and “Nehemiah.” In the ancient manuscripts, however, these two books are one. In modern times this one book is often called “Ezra-Nehemiah”—not the most inspiring of titles, to be sure, but indicative of its two most prominent characters.¹

This book is far from the most widely used or discussed books of the Bible,² but, like all of Scripture, is inspired and useful for instruction in a godly life (2 Tim 3:16-17).

The present commentary aims to discuss the book of Ezra-Nehemiah (which I will often abbreviate “EN”), exploring its main themes and touching on some of its details and its implications for Christian life today.³

The translation that the comments will assume is the Christian Standard Bible (CSB), available online (at csbible.com and elsewhere). That said, most of the English versions in wide use do not differ greatly from the CSB.

Before the commentary itself there is a series of introductory sections discussing matters such as the background, text, and date of the book. Here is a list of the introductory topics covered:

Background of the Book

Kings and Chronology

The Prehistory, Authorship, and Transmission of the Book

Languages, Genre, and Literary Features

Overview of the Book

The commentary is broken into sections. For each chapter of EN, there is a summary. Discussions on extended passages will precede comments on individual verses. (Bibliographic information can be found at the very end of this document.)

After the commentary a number of appendices explore certain topics at some length:

1. Themes in Ezra-Nehemiah

2. The Differences between Ezra 2 and Nehemiah 7

¹ Ancient books often did not have titles, and that is the case here.

² To take just two examples: a book-length treatment of the theological significance of temple imagery in the Scriptures (viz., Beale) cites EN on only three of its pages; and another monograph (viz., Martin), this one about the land promise in the story arc of Scriptures, cites EN on four of its pages.

³ For the most part, I save space by not interacting with other commentaries on EN. But there are a number of good commentaries available. Special mention must be made of Steinmann’s—tremendously detailed and careful, and theologically conservative and pastoral.

3. *Davidic Kingship in Ezra-Nehemiah*
4. *Ezra 4-6: Sequence and Composition*
5. *Why is the Temple Rebuilt?*
6. *Views on the Mass Divorce*
7. *Christ and Ezra-Nehemiah*

A list of abbreviations occurs after this preface.

Those following along in the original language should be aware that at times the versification of the Hebrew Bible differs from that of the main English translations.

Abbreviations

cf.: compare

CSB: Christian Standard Bible

E: Ezra

e.g.: for example

esp: especially

EN: Ezra-Nehemiah

G: the Old Greek version of Ezra-Nehemiah (that is, 1 Esdras) and/or the Hebrew text underlying it

lit.: literally

M: Masoretic Text (more or less represented by the Leningrad Codex, an edition of which is at tanach.us)

N: Nehemiah

NLT: New Living Translation

OT: Old Testament

viz., that is, namely

Introduction: Background of the Book

After seventy years of exile, it was time to return home. God's people, having ignored centuries of warnings from God through the prophets, continued to love Yahweh their God with all their heart, mind, and strength, and they had not loved their neighbors as themselves. So their kingdom—itsself a fragment of what had once been a much larger kingdom under Saul, David, and Solomon—was brought to a violent end by the ferocious Babylonians, who carried off the majority of the population to Mesopotamia (the remaining Judean population facing further unrest and poverty, all but withering into nothingness). Eventually, ownership of the empire changed hands, the Medo-Persian Empire seizing Babylon and its territories. (See below for a list of the new kings.)

While the Medes and Persians were hardly afraid of waging war on their foes, the new empire developed several related policies that promoted willing, rather than coerced, loyalty from their subject peoples. They divided the empire into provinces (or satrapies),⁴ regions that, while ultimately under the control of the throne, enjoyed in times of peace a considerable measure of self-government. And all over the empire, the monarchs encouraged religious toleration—not out of a modern sense of pluralism as inherently valuable, but out an interest to satisfy local peoples with the continuance of their ancestral traditions so that, with no fundamental reason for hatred of the Medo-Persian (over time, the Persian) Empire, they would pay taxes without complaint and show reluctance to revolt. In practice, it is less than clear that this theory of the Persian rulers worked nearly as well as they hoped. But for the surviving remnant of Yahweh's people, it was everything.

With the Persian king Cyrus allowing—and indeed, underwriting—a return of the Jews to their land, a portion of God's people set out for Judea. At some level, they were aware that what awaited there was a land in ruins—broken walls, collapsed houses, and no temple for the worship of their God. But the mission to rebuild would be even more difficult than they had anticipated. The book of EN tells the story of this rebuilding.

⁴ The exact number, names, and boundaries of these are changeable and uncertain. See, e.g., Boardman (153ff).

Introduction: Kings and Chronology

Here is a list of the Achaemenid kings (after Steinmann, 66-68; similarly Kidner, 11-12):

1. Cyrus
2. Cambyses
3. Darius I
4. Ahasuerus (=Xerxes)
5. Artaxerxes I
6. Darius II
7. Artaxerxes II
8. Artaxerxes III
9. Arses
10. Darius III

Notes: (1) There is dispute about the number of kings; the list above is, however, pretty reflective of the modern consensus. (2) The use of Roman numerals to distinguish between monarchs of the same name is a modern convention, so neither in the Bible nor in other ancient sources do we have labels like “Artaxerxes I,” “Artaxerxes II.” (3) Confusingly, the fourth king on this list is generally known as Xerxes (after the Greek rendering of the Persian) outside of English-language Bible translations, but as Ahasuerus (after the Latin rendering of the Hebrew rendering of the Persian) in English-language Bible translations (including the CSB). (4) Not all of these men are mentioned in the Bible.⁵

Here is a list of some important dates (culled from a larger list in Steinmann, 66-67):⁶

- 537 BC: Cyrus decrees a return
- 533 BC: Altar rebuilt
- 515 BC: Temple rebuilt
- 458 BC: Ezra arrives
- 445 BC: Nehemiah becomes governor
- 445 BC: Walls rebuilt
- 445 BC: Ezra reads the law
- 433 BC: Nehemiah returns to Mesopotamia
- 429 or 428 BC: Nehemiah returns

Introduction: The Prehistory, Authorship, and Transmission of the Book

The book of EN has a prehistory in the sense that considerable portions of the book are verbatim (or at most, lightly adapted) quotations from earlier books. This is seen most clearly in the fact that in one part of the book, Ezra himself narrates events in the first person, while in another lengthy section of the book, Nehemiah does the same thing. Neither Ezra nor Nehemiah, then, is the sole author of EN. Rather, both men apparently wrote memoirs of some kind,⁷ and either one of them or a third individual put (some or all of) these two memoirs together, along with other historical documentation and narration, into a single book. Many have held that Ezra is the man most responsible for the book, though a good case can also be made for Nehemiah⁸ or for some unknown later individual.⁹ In the end, we have to admit we do not

⁵ Cambyses’ was an eventful reign, yet its (mis)adventures have no direct bearing on the history described in the Bible—a striking example of the fact that biblical history, like all history, is selective: it does not mention everything that happened, but only those events considered relevant by the historian(s).

⁶ “B.C.” stands for “before Christ.” Other historians use the term “B.C.E.,” “Before the Common Era.” Either way, these dates count backward from (roughly) the date of Jesus’ birth to the virgin Mary.

⁷ “Memoir” is the term most regularly used in scholarly discussions of this point, but it is an imprecise term.

⁸ He was the younger of the two, and there is a deuterocanonical, but possibly accurate, tradition that Nehemiah founded an archive (2 Maccabees 2:13).

⁹ The last datable figure in the book is Jadda (N 12:22), who served as high priest approximately from 370 BC to 330 BC (Steinmann, 584).

know.¹⁰

Given what we have seen about the prehistory of this book, in this commentary I will use the terms “author” and “editor” as synonyms. Whoever is responsible for EN carefully and artfully assembled the book out of various preexisting documents, probably with material written by himself or herself, to form a unified, coherent, and meaningful whole.

Once the book was composed, its Hebrew and Aramaic text had to be transmitted and translated for its message to reach more and more people. Both transmitting and translating the text involve certain difficulties. Copying a lengthy text by hand or with a printing text (and in some ways, even with modern technology) is tedious, and it is easy for mistakes to creep in. And in the nature of the case no two languages map on to each other fully, and, as time went by certain point of the original Hebrew and Aramaic became difficult to understand even to native speakers of those languages (much as, e.g., Shakespeare presents many obscurities to modern native speakers of English). But there are many manuscripts—some ancient and many medieval—of EN available, together with certain ancient translations which, to judge from a careful reading of their content, must have been made from ancient manuscripts extremely similar to the ones that survive to the present; and these manuscripts give many evidences of being reliable witnesses.¹¹ At times, questions come up about the original wording of EN,¹² but all in all, there is ample reason to be confident that we have the overall message, and most or all of the details, of the book readily available. And, as mentioned, the book is not always easy to translate, but, thanks to those who have labored to trace the words and grammar of Hebrew and Aramaic, little is lost in translation in the end.¹³

Introduction: Languages, Genre, and Literary Features

It is an unusual feature of EN that it contains not one but two languages.¹⁴ The reasons for this are debated. It might simply be that some of the source material is Aramaic and is adopted by the editor of EN without translation; or the shift of language might be offering signals about who a passage principally concerns or what atmosphere is being cultivated.¹⁵

It is important to read any work, ancient or modern, in accordance with the norms of the genre in which it has been composed. The words of a poem are to be understood differently than the words of a newspaper. Ryken and Ryken describe Ezra as mainly “historical narrative, in the specific form of a return story they narrates the return of groups of people to their homeland after exile,” but also making use of “a variety of documentary material—lists of people and supplies, transcripts of official documents, the genealogy of Ezra, royal and other official letters, memoirs, and prayers” (635). Nehemiah they describe as similar, yet displaying “a stronger narrative flair” and “the flavor of a memoir” (650). They point out that Ezra-Nehemiah gives a “prominent role” to “strong leaders” (636; cf. 650), but point out that “documentary material regularly interrupts the flow of the narrative, showing the historical impulse of the author” (650).

The description given so far is reminiscent of OT narrative in general, beginning with the

¹⁰ It is often supposed that the same person wrote both Chronicles (that is, the books of 1 and 2 Chronicles, which in Hebrew are really one book) and EN, but there are serious reasons to doubt this. For instance, various linguistic factors suggest a different author (see Japhet *passim*).

¹¹ Another witness to (a small part of) the text of EN is Chronicles. As noted above, I do not think that these two books share their author; and, contrary to some MSS, I think the best evidence places Chronicles *after* EN. But in the event, I do not think that there are any passages in which M-EN is marred by scribal error but where Chronicles alone bears the true text.

¹² In order to avoid being overly technical, the present commentary generally avoids going into the details of the textual issues, but I did make something of an exception in Appendix 2.

¹³ As noted in the Preface, the translation assumed in this commentary unless otherwise noted is the Christian Standard Bible. There are plenty of other good translations available, such as the English Standard Version, Rotherham’s Emphasized Bible, and the New Living Translation.

¹⁴ The books of Daniel and (to a very small extent) Jeremiah also feature some Aramaic.

¹⁵ Appendix 4 will also touch on this issue to a limited extent.

Pentateuch (which, it must be said in broad agreement with John Sailhamer, has a narrational pulse even beyond the book of Genesis); for instance, narratives concerning David and Solomon are interspersed with lists of notable warriors and architectural plans for the Temple. So EN, at least in its overall shape, is not breaking new literary ground, but rather stands in continuity with its predecessors in the Hebrew Bible. But the degree to which EN relies on lists of names and exact figures is notable.

Another characteristic, but not unique, feature of EN is its frequent use of first person narrative. It is also notable that EN makes extensive use of various sources, presenting a sort of pastiche of the period of return (see the section above on the prehistory and composition of EN).

Old Testament narratives are generally straightforward and clear in their statement of historical events. They eschew irrelevant detail (e.g., descriptions of what people looked like are given only where that information is important for understanding the events that follow), though, as noted above, they are frequently intertwined with documentary material (modern English-language works tend to separate these two types of material). Another notable feature of OT narrative is a general reluctance to plainly assign value to actions. That is to say, rather than saying “X happened,” and then saying, “X was an evil deed,” praise or blame is implied only very subtly, or indeed is left to the reader (or listener, for in ancient times most people were probably exposed to Scripture by listening to someone else read it) to infer. It is certainly not the case that the OT writers held an amoral view of history, only that for some reason they preferred for their listeners to discover the moral truths involved for themselves.

Finally, I observe in passing that there are various overlaps between content and structure between the book of EN and the Book of Acts. Both involve a historical framework (with embedded first-person narratives), showcase two key leaders (Ezra and Nehemiah; Peter and Paul), a preoccupation with the temple in Jerusalem, describe repeated opposition to God’s work, describe the relationship of secular authorities with God’s people in a nuanced way, and depict the reconstitution of God’s people.¹⁶

Introduction: Overview of the Book

There are various ways to divide the book and its subsections more or less finely, but here I will draw attention to what I think might be the most helpful way to look at the book. Ezra-Nehemiah can be viewed as showing, with variations, basically the same story arc four times:

1. Returning from exile (E 1-2), celebrating the Festival of Shelters and the laying of the temple foundation with joy (3), surmounting opposition (4:1-6:15), and dedicating the temple and celebrating festivals with joy (6:16-22).

2. Returning from exile (E 7-8), yet discovering sin still present (9-10).

3. Returning from exile (N 1-2), surmounting opposition (3-7), celebrating the completion of the city walls and the Festival of Shelters with joy (8), yet discovering sin still present (9-10).

4. Returning to the holy city (N 11:1-12:26), celebrating the dedication of the walls with joy (12:27ff), yet discovering sin still present (13).

This scheme, of course, oversimplifies things, yet I think gives a helpful wide-angle lens on the book.

Ezra Chapter One

As often with OT narrative,¹⁷ the book opens with a timestamp.¹⁸ Surely this concern with chronology demonstrates a keen interest in historical facts among OT writers—so much so that the scholarly commonplace that Herodotus is “the father of history” requires qualification: while his achievement was signal, it was anticipated in important respects by more ancient writers. Christianity, the inheritor of ancient Judaism, rests on a historical foundation (the death and resurrection of Jesus, and everything that

¹⁶ On this last point, see E 6:17 below and cf. Peterson, 119f.

¹⁷ Gen 1:1, Num 1:1, Dt 1:1ff, Josh 1:1, Jdg 1:1, Ruth 1:1, Est 1:1; also at times with other genres—see, e.g., Isa 1:1, Ps 3:superscription

¹⁸ Strictly speaking, the very first morpheme is a conjunction (ו, “and”); this, too, is quite common in the OT, perhaps in imitation of the majority of the books of the Pentateuch.

led up to the work of Christ), not on mere notions separable from events.

In the present case, the opening narrative is tied to *the first year of King Cyrus of Persia*. Ancient timestamps could only be relative—tying material to some well-known person, thing, or event (e.g., Am 1:1)—not absolute, since a continuous numbering of years (2020, 2021, 2022, etc.) had not yet been invented. The employment of Cyrus’s reign as an anchor point is efficient: by it the author not only refers readers to a well-known era (Cyrus was the first ruler of a major empire, and an empire that was probably still in power in the days of the book’s first readers), but also reminds them of the momentous prophecies of Isaiah (esp. 44:18). Right out the gate, the author announces that epochal developments are afoot.

Ordinarily, in narrative passages the first verb of a Hebrew clause (here “roused,” הָעִיר) occurs at or near the beginning of that clause. But in this instance the author makes his readers wait, interposing a phrase that makes explicit what was implicit in the reference to Cyrus: what is about to happen in the narrative happens *in order to fulfill the word of the LORD* (לְכַלּוֹת דְּבַר יְהוָה). The events to be described in this chapter are not accidental or incidental, but the necessary outworking of Yahweh’s plan and purpose. The author thus stands in a long line of writers who take care to attribute events to the need for God’s word to prove its faithfulness. (cf., e.g., Num 23:19, Josh 23:15, 1 Ki 2:27; the verbiage here is all but identical in the parallel passage, 2 Chron 36:22). The later gospel writers, for their part (particularly the author of Matthew), will emphasize the fulfillment of prophecy through constant repetition (not to mention the fact that Matthew begins with a genealogy that reaches back into OT times). So it is that undergirding Christianity is not only history as the events of the past, but history as the fulfillment of God’s plan; our God is the Lord of history.

What “word of the LORD” is being fulfilled? The word “through Jeremiah.” Chapter and verse numbers did not exist in ancient times, but based on the material that follows, the passage that the author has in mind is apparently Jer 29:10 (cf. 25:11-12). The substance of Jeremiah’s prophecy is as follows: after an interval of seventy years, the displacement of the Jewish people from their land would end, and a new era for that land would begin.

This prophesied season of renewal was at one level the brainchild of Cyrus, who on the one hand exhibited great military skill in overcoming many adversaries (among them the Babylonians) and on the other hand modeled self-interested benevolence in supporting local religions (among them, that of the Jews). On another level, the renewal was not Cyrus’s doing at all: it was Yahweh to stirred up the spirit of the Persian emperor. King Solomon was right to say (Pr 21:1) that a monarch’s mind is God’s tool. As hinted above, Cyrus had reasons to think himself clever with regard to his policies toward subject peoples. Furthermore, his protestations (vv2-4) notwithstanding, the Persian monarch had no concern for Yahweh (Isa 45:4).¹⁹ Yet God—whether through the evolution of Persian political thought, the genetics and childhood experiences that shaped Cyrus’s disposition, or whatever other means the divine wisdom employed—so arranged things that Cyrus took the actions that he did, resulting in the fulfillment of the prophetic word and the advancement of salvation history.

Having been stirred to action, Cyrus moves decisively. He makes his decree circulate throughout his empire in both audible (קוֹל, “proclamation”) and written (מִכְתָּב, “written document”) formats,²⁰ making his policy *viz-à-viz* Jerusalem quite clear: the Jews are permitted and encouraged to return to Judah and to rebuild the temple. To make this possible, local communities are to foot the bill.

This edict having been issued, certain leaders of the Judahite, Benjamite, and Levitical tribes begin their journey homeward. As with their emperor, they act because their *spirit God stirred*. Through prophecy, through his work in the spirit of the ruler, and through his work in the spirit of the ruled, God is directing the course of history. In fact, most of God’s sovereign rule over the earth is actualized not with fire, smoke, and thunder, but through seemingly mundane, ordinary happenings and through his silent

¹⁹ “Cyrus was not especially favouring the Judeans, rather they were simply part of his policy of *glasnost* for all religions” (Fyall, 90).

²⁰ In the ancient Middle East, rulers, burdened with a message to share (often a message of their own strength and/or wisdom and generosity), would often send messengers to communicate verbally and set up pillars (or, in the Persian case, even carve cliff faces) with the news (even though most of the population was illiterate).

promptings in human hearts. Indeed, in the present case not only do many Jews launch themselves out on a daring adventure—the distance between them and Jerusalem is vast, and the prospects facing them there are unclear—but many non-Jews supply above and beyond Cyrus’s call for supplies. Not only that, but Cyrus, not slack in effort, directs his own treasurer to remove from storage what Nebuchadnezzar had pillaged from Yahweh’s temple; these items Mithredath, with all the care for numbers that a man of his office carries with him (he *counted out*), entrusts to Sheshbazzar, leader of the migrants. The list of these items underscores once more than God’s promises (Jer 27:19-22) always come true. After decades of night, a new day has dawned for the people of God.

E 1:1 *king* (מֶלֶךְ): This is the traditional rendering, but one could also render “emperor”: the Hebrew makes no distinction between “king” and “emperor.”

E 1:1 *the word of the LORD* (דְּבַר יְהוָה): More lit., “the word of Yahweh.” In the CSB, when a capital L is followed by ORD in small capitals, the underlying Hebrew is not the term for “lord, sovereign” (אֲדֹנָי), but rather the name “Yahweh” (יהוה), meaning “He Is” (the first-person version of this is seen in Ex 3:14).

E 1:1 *spirit* (רוּחַ): Cyrus’ inner disposition, his will.

E 1:2 The substance of the proclamation is provided in this and in the following verses. The original, of course, would not likely have been in Hebrew. Most probably it would have been in Aramaic (perhaps based on an original draft in Persian), but there is no reason to doubt the accuracy of the translation.

E 1:2 *The LORD* (יהוה): Cyrus’s appeal to Yahweh as the giver of his lands is disingenuous; Cyrus is merely saying what he thinks the Jews want to hear. Yet he speaks more truly than he knows.

E 1:2 *God of the heavens* (אֱלֹהֵי הַשָּׁמַיִם): The lowercase “g” represents the perspective of the speaker, Cyrus, who was not a monotheist. Cyrus was not a monotheist, so translating “God” (viz. with an initial capital letter) represents the vantage point of a believer—certainly the vantage point for the narrator of EN. But as far as capturing Cyrus’ own view, it might be better to translate “god.”

The phrase “the God of the heavens”²¹ (sometimes extended to “the God of the heavens and the earth,” or something similar) is often found in speech directed to or coming from gentiles, especially gentile rulers. The phrase originally intended to underscore the universal scope of God’s sovereignty (as opposed to the pagan deities, who were conceived of as having limited spheres of influence or localized sway),²² but likely was heard by many gentiles to mean that the Jews worshiped a being connected in some way with the sky.²³

E 1:2 *has given me all the kingdoms of the earth*: Cyrus, following standard Mesopotamian practice (he was from the Iranian plateau, but in many respects chose to model his rule on the Mesopotamian kings of old), wildly exaggerates the extent of his control.

E 1:2 *appointed* (פָּקַד): A concise and reasonably comprehensive definition of the G stem of the root פָּקַד is “to assign a person or a thing to what the subject believes is its proper or appropriate status or position in an organizational order” (Creason, 41).

²¹ The CSB is a bit inconsistent in handling the Hebrew אֱלֹהֵי הַשָּׁמַיִם and its Aramaic equivalent, rendering “the God of heaven” in Gen 24:3, 7, and Ps 136:26 (אֱלֹהֵי הַשָּׁמַיִם), but “the God of the heavens” in 2 Chron 36:23, E 1:2, 5:11, 12, 6:9, 7:12, 21, 23 (twice), N 1:4, 5, 2:4, 20, Dan 2:18, 19, 37, 44, and Jonah 1:9.

²² This usage seems to be continued in the NT (Rev 11:13, 16:11).

²³ Cf. a similar confusion in 1 Ki 20:26ff. At times, it might be in order to ward off misconceptions like this that language along the line of “possessor of heaven and earth” (Gen 14:22) appears in the OT. (It occasionally shows up in the NT as well.)

E 1:2 *to build* (לִבְנוֹת): Or “to rebuild” (for this meaning of בָּנָה, see Koehler and Baumgartner 1: 139a; note also the usage of this Semitic root in this sense in the Mesha inscription).

E 1:2 *house* (בֵּית): In the ancient Middle East, “house” could mean “temple” (more or less literally understood as the, or a, dwelling place of the god associated with it).

E 1:3 *among you*: Cyrus addresses himself to the various residents of his empire concerning the Jews in their midst.

E 1:3 *may his God be with him*: There is an ambiguity here, where “his god” (אֱלֹהֵי) could also mean “his gods.” (The ancient languages did not have capitalization, for we cannot appeal to the big G of the CSB.) Whether Cyrus was aware of the monotheistic beliefs of the Jewish people is uncertain. For his purposes, he is expressing his own goodwill toward the Jews.

E 1:3 *may he go* (וַיַּעַל): Or, “let him go up.” The verb is more lit. “go *up*,” because most routes into Jerusalem involve going uphill.

At least in Hebrew (and also in a potential Aramaic original, though probably not in Old Persian) this is ambiguous as to whether Cyrus is *commanding* the Jews to return to their land or *permitting* them to do so if they choose. As things turned out, many Jews did not take the opportunity to emigrate (as evidenced, for example, by the book of Esther), and the Persian authorities did not insist on the matter. Given the earlier words “may his god(s) be with him,” however, Cyrus’s words are not mere permission, but permission with encouragement (making it all the more ironic that not all Jews took him up on his offer).

E 1:4 *be assisted by the men of the region with silver, etc.*: That is, the local community of each Jewish head of family is to defray the expenses of the trip and of the temple rebuilding. (Formally, the language is ambiguous as in v3 [see above], but where finances are concerned Cyrus’s wish is his subjects’ command.) Such would probably be the most efficient and direct way of financing this venture (certainly the exiled Jews would have been in no position to pay their own way). Perhaps some sort of tax holiday or the like in the areas most affected would have been used to ameliorate the burden on the non-Jewish populations involved, but in any case Cyrus felt the long-term investment in goodwill toward the empire on the part of the Jews (and other resettled populations; the Assyrians and Babylonians had moved vast numbers of people around) was worth the short-term cost.

E 1:4 *along with a freewill offering for the house of God in Jerusalem*: This reflects Cyrus’s intent fastidiously to observe local religious customs. Such concern for cultic propriety would generate goodwill among his subject peoples, and perhaps, Cyrus likely reasoned, undergird his own health and prosperity through the prayers offered on his behalf across the empire.

E 1:5 *family heads* (רֹאשֵׁי הָאֲבוֹת): Cf. Koehler and Baumgartner 2: 1166b. These are men who (by an unclear mechanism, whether seniority, respected character, or some varied set of indistinct criteria) provided general leadership for an extended family or clan.

E 1:7 *the article’s of the LORD’s house*: The temple was more than just a structure. Rather, it was an extensive site where many elaborate activities took place, requiring a huge array and number of tools made to exacting specifications laid out in the law of Moses.

E 1:8 *Sheshbazzar* (שֶׁשְׁבַצָּר): Who exactly this man was and what his role was has been a matter of intense debate in modern scholarship (see Steinmann, 30-36). Trying to summarize, let alone thoroughly handle, the issues involved would take us very far afield. What we know is that he was a prominent man from the

tribe of Judah,²⁴ who early on played a major role in leading the returning community.

E 1:8 *the prince* (הַנָּשִׂיא): An ancient term (see Koehler and Baumgartner 1: 727b), the meaning of which is not wholly clear. In some instances, the meaning seems to be “tribal leader,” but this does not cover all cases. Likely as not, the significance of the term varied from place to place and from era to era. In fact, its vagueness might be precisely what made it a suitable designation for Sheshbazzar: any claim on his part to be a “king” (מֶלֶךְ) would potentially be threatening to the Persian imperial government. Also avoided here is the term שָׂר (usually rendered “prince,” though the Hebrew term is not as specific as the modern English term would imply), though it is used a handful of times (in innocuous ways) in the book of Nehemiah (e.g., 3:9).

E 1:11 5,400: This figure is problematic in that it does not equal the sum of the items just mentioned. Perhaps not coincidentally, there are obscurities in the text and translation at this point: the meaning of several of the terms used in vv9-11 are unclear, so the exact terminology used by the CSB should be viewed as tentative, and the significance of the textual witnesses here is also debatable. Every proposed solution is somewhat problematic, though some seemingly get us close to a solution. Perhaps new discoveries or further research will clear things up; for the time being, we must admit that vv9-11 are unclear in the details, while the larger point remains: in ancient times, the temple implements were carefully tracked.

Ezra Chapter Two

The momentous return to Jerusalem launched in the previous chapter is documented here in this chapter. The journey from Babylon to Jerusalem must have been arduous, yet was so overshadowed by the importance of the destination that the author of EN felt no need to include the details. What *is* carefully detailed is the list of people returning.²⁵ For the purposes of EN, listing all the names of the individuals involved would have made the book too large (that there were more or less complete genealogies for most families of this era is implied by vv61-63), but key names and places with associated numbers are meticulously tabulated.²⁶

Naturally enough, mention of the leadership is made before the detailed listing of the returning families and groups. It is a fact of human history that many major events are instigated (for better or worse) by people who exercise leadership (whether assigned or emergent), and it is also true that to a major extent human flourishing is promoted by skillful leadership or stamped out by poor leadership. Zerubbabel is mentioned first, and his key significance will be expanded on in the next chapter. Second and also important is Jeshua (his role will be discussed in connection with the next chapter, but see also the comment on 2:2 below). Nehemiah is not the Nehemiah who will dominate the second portion of EN; apparently that name was a common one in those days.²⁷

The leadership having been mentioned, attention turns to the returning people as whole. They are enumerated under several headings: (1) families described first in terms of lines of descent; (2) groups described in terms of their ancestral hometown; (3) the priests; (4) the levites; (5) the singers; (6) the gatekeepers; (7) the temple servants; (8) the descendants of Solomon’s servants; (9) insufficiently

²⁴ His name is Babylonian, but in the book of Daniel we see Jewish men being given Babylonian names. Indeed, being evidently from a prominent family from an important tribe, he was a prime candidate for (attempted) indoctrination from Mesopotamian authorities.

²⁵ In this context those living in the United States can celebrate the degree to which modern technology and research is allowing people of African descent to trace their ancestry.

²⁶ Indeed, in the Hebrew many visual distinctions are made via paragraph breaks between families.

²⁷ The name belongs to at least three different individuals in the book of EN, and there is a related name in E 2:2 (as I reconstruct the text; cf. “The Differences between Ezra 7 and Nehemiah 7”) and N 7:7. “Nehemiah” means something like “Yahweh has provided comfort,” using the same Hebrew term for comfort (נָחַם) that Isaiah had used long before (40:1). The reuse of that Hebrew term might not be coincidental: perhaps it is an expression of faith and hope that that promise was coming true.

documented Israelites; (9) insufficiently documents priests. The mixture of descent, locale, and vocation might prompt the inquiry as to whether these tallies overlap (so that, e.g., someone could be descended from Parosh but also a resident of Bethlehem), but this is unlikely, because the sum of the numbers falls well below, not above, the sum given in 2:64 (on the figure given there, see further the comment on that verse below). Rather, the first group probably enumerates residents specifically of Jerusalem and who do not fall into one of the vocational categories mentioned in lists 3-9 (so also Steinmann, 170). This approach is eminently justifiable, given the importance of Jerusalem among all the cities of Israel on the one hand and the important distinctions in vocation among ancient Israelites on the other. There is a difficulty, however, in that N 11:1 implies that in Nehemiah's day the great majority of the population lived outside of the city limits of Jerusalem. But this difficulty is not insuperable: on the one hand, the impulse, early in the unfolding of the return from exile, to take up residence in the holy city is easy to imagine; on the other hand, the gradual dispersion of this urban density, in the face of growing persecution and gnawing insecurities, is not hard to understand.

The barrage of names and numbers, while not comprehensive (the documents used must have been quite bulky), is considerable. The compiler showed great thoroughness and care, giving exact figures and careful differentiation among different groups, and also reserving space to record the disputed genealogies (on which see the comments on 2:59-63 below). As mentioned in connection with chapter one, historicity is clearly an important claim of the Bible concerning itself. But the historicity of the return from captivity is probably not the primary burden of this passage in Ezra. Rather, the main things are the specificity and the continuity of the return: certain people returned,²⁸ and these people represented the continuing survival of God's people;²⁹ God had long ago promised to redeem his people (Ex 3:7ff), and his covenant is sure (Jer 29:10). The list ends, as Steinmann (170) aptly observes, with a reference to all "Israel."

E 2:1 *province* (מדינה): To be distinguished from the meaning in modern Hebrew ("state, nation"). The ancient meaning is "province" or possibly "city" (as in Aramaic). The meaning "city" here is unlikely, for a number of reasons (e.g., the book of Esther presents a picture of the Jewish people as living in a number of cities during the Persian period).

E 2:2 *Zerubbabel* (זרובבל): A descendant of King David, who was one of (at some point apparently the) leader of the returning community. See Appendix 3 for more on Zerubbabel.

E 2:2 *Jeshua* (ישוע): More lit., "Jesus." The name "Joshua" (יהושע), meaning "Yahweh brings salvation" became, through normal language change over time, "Jeshua" (with the same meaning). Both are rendered by the Greek Ἰησοῦς, which in the NT is normally rendered "Jesus" in English.³⁰

E 2:2 *Nehemiah* (נהמיה): As mentioned above, this is not the key figure of the second major part of EN

²⁸ "For most modern readers, the listing of names in Ezra 2 elicits only a quick scan, or a skip and a jump to chapter 3. We know next to nothing about these people. They seem rather ordinary and unexceptional, a dusty group repossessing a dilapidated city in Palestine. But these people... broke with convention. While a majority of Jews remained in Babylon, complacent and content, the list gives evidence of those hearty souls who followed God's call and set their face toward Jerusalem. They probably didn't feel extraordinary in and of themselves, but they did feel the compelling force of God's purpose and their role in that great design. So they broke from the crowd; they ventured out and participated in the adventure God set before them. We, too, can have a hand in the purposes and events of God's design. It will be enough if we do our bit because in the wide world it is not about us but about the glory of God" (Larson and Dahlen, 26)

²⁹ "So these were the living portions of Israel, roots and all, for replanting. But the fundamental motive for this careful grouping was not social but religious. This is the holy nation, given a new chance to live up to its calling" (Kidner, 39-40).

³⁰ The CSB is inconsistent in its rendering of this name, even with regard to this individual: the same man in Hag 1:1 etc. called "Joshua."

(who comes on the scene only later according to N 2:1), but another man by the same name.

E 2:16 of Hezekiah: “Literally, ‘the descendants of Ater to Hezekiah.’ Translations and commentaries are divided on the force of the preposition לְ, “to,” here. It may mean that these people are from one line of several lines of the descendants of Ater, namely, the line that includes King Hezekiah. לְ has the same force in Ezra 2:34, 40” (Steinmann, 157). Alternatively, לְ might mean “namely,” so that Ater has an alternative (regnal?) name, Hezekiah.

E 2:26 Ramah: lit., “*the* Ramah,” that is, “the Height.”

E 2:27 Michmas (מכמש): A dialectical variation on Michmash (מכמש).

E 2:40 Jeshua (ישוע): Another man by this name; cf. on v2 above.

E 2:43 The temple servants (הנתינים): Among the alternative renderings is “acolytes”—not, of course, referring to any of the various positions and roles that later developed in certain Christian denominations, but nevertheless in something of an overlap in usage: Christian acolytes, though not themselves ordained, render assistance in some of the more menial tasks associated with the work of the clergy. In the context of Ezra’s day, these men, who were not priests in any strict sense, assisted in the manifold labors associated with the functions of the temple.

E 2:59-63 Without proven genealogies, these men could not serve in the temple. The Urim and Thummim are somewhat mysterious, but they were a tool somehow used to learn God’s will in certain situations (Num 27:21, 1 Sam 14:41, 28:6). Apparently these no longer existed, but hope was held out that one day they would be rediscovered. “Churches today might not have access to the Urim and Thummim, nor do genealogies typically qualify a person for church membership or leadership. Nevertheless, measures [should] exist to achieve a balance between being inclusive and protective” (Ulrich, 42).

E 2:64 42,360: This sum is given both here and in N 7:66, but neither the numbers in Ezra chapter 2 nor those in Nehemiah chapter 7 equal this sum when added together. Indeed, the sum is about 12,000 short. It is true that there are numerous textual variants among extant witnesses concerning many of the smaller numbers, but it would require a drastic rewriting of our sources to make the numbers add up to 42,360. The deuterocanonical book 1 Esdras states that the tally in vv1-63 only includes those were twelve and older (5:41), but “1 Esdras often contains glosses that are simple attempts by the translator to make sense of the text before him” (Steinmann, 175). Steinmann (176) tentatively outlines a solution which seems the most plausible one advanced, viz. that “the individual clan totals do not include women. This would mean that the approximately 30,000 men were accompanied by about 12,000 women to arrive at the total of 42,360, a ratio of about 2.5 men for every one woman. This suggestion is often dismissed by scholars who believe the ratio of men to women is far too high and that the numbers of men and women should be closer to being equal. However, it would have been relatively easy for a single man—especially a young bachelor—to leave his life in Babylon as compared to a married man with a family... Moreover, it would explain the reason for the later intractable problem that was first addressed in Ezra’s day (Ezra 10) and then had to be confronted again in Nehemiah’s day (Nehemiah 13)... it would take a number of generations before such an imbalance [of genders] could be rectified.”

Ezra Chapter Three

A mere seven months after returning to the land after a seventy year absence, God’s people turns their attention to proper worship. Both the priestly and the governmental classes (*Jeshua... along with Zerubbabel*) throw their energies behind the project.

Paying close attention to the mosaic legislation,³¹ the people construct the altar, that is, the edifice upon which animal and other sacrifices are made. They do so even though they are afraid of retaliation from the surrounding peoples—a rational fear, as later chapters of EN will show. Evidently, the principle underlying Isa 8:12-13 has been burned into their minds: the nations respect military power and political leverage, but God’s people will, when thinking clearly, think above all of divine holiness.

A fitting date has been chosen for the resumption of sacrifices, namely the Festival of Shelters (also known as the Festival of Booths, or Sukkot³²). Briefly put,³³ the festival involves (1) traveling to Jerusalem, (2) staying in temporary shelters made from tree branches, leaves, and fronds in remembrance of the exodus from Egypt, and (3) offering an elaborate series of sacrifices; additionally, every seventh year would also see the cancellation of Jewish debts and the reading of the law to all the people. Celebration of the escape from Egypt must have been layered with celebration of escape from Babylon; God’s people, having found but then lost rest, has found it again. After the festival with all of its unique specifications is over, the standing pattern of regular sacrifices reemerges (v5).

All this, the author emphasizes, preceded construction of the wider temple complex (v6). Furthermore, the people spare no expense in seeing it done well (v7). The people evidently feel that reimplementation of the sacrificial system is more important than the reconstruction of the external edifice. This instinct is surely correct, since the first commandment after the Ten Words (Ex 20:1-17) and the repetition of the prohibition of idols (vv22-23) is for the construction of an altar (vv24-26). The tabernacle, and particularly Solomon’s temple, was large and impressive, full of expensive fixtures and tools and beautiful design and artwork; even so, the beating heart of the temple body was the act of sacrifice. The Christian faith, likewise, is in some ways a sprawling complex, each wing and room being, when properly considered, beautiful and engaging; yet the whole structure derives its meaning from its foundation, which is Christ crucified (1 Cor 2:2).

After a gap in time,³⁴ the people make all the necessary arrangements for beginning work on the larger temple complex. As the symbolic first step, the laying of the foundation, sees the light of day, they reach not only back to the appropriate mosaic legislation, but also to the commands (1 Chr 6:31ff, 25:1ff) of King David (v10). The author summarizes the singing with these words: “For he is good; his lovingkindness to Israel endures forever.” The theme of God’s goodness runs throughout the Bible and the second clause in particular is perhaps the most common refrain in Scripture (Jer 33:11, 1 Chron 16:34, v41, 2 Chron 5:13, 7:3, v6, 20:21, Ps 100:5, 106:1, 107:1, 118:1-4, v29, 136:1-26). The music of this moment has led God’s people to enjoy some of the most important ideas found in God’s Word; and right down to the present corporate worship often has this effect.

The last two verses (vv12-13) are poignant. Some of the very elderly among the people have childhood memories of Solomon’s temple, and this new temple “seems... like nothing by comparison” (Hag 2:3). The glories of yesteryear are gone, and the best efforts of the new generation bring disappointment. Sadness thus mingles with celebration, and the sound of the two could not be distinguished. So it is with God’s people today as well: they are free from the tyranny of sin (Rom 8:1), yet are afflicted by its effects (v23); they rejoice more than words can say in their belief in Jesus (1 Pet 1:8), yet his absence often leaves them fasting rather than feasting (Mat 9:15); they eagerly await his return (2 Pet 3:12), in the meantime remembering his death (1 Cor 11:26). But just as Zerubbabel’s temple, meager though it was, presaged the coming peace that God would bring (Hag 2:9), so current troubles lay the groundwork for future glory (2 Cor 4:17) when “sorrow and sighing will flee” (Isa 35:10, 51:11).

The tremendously loud noise with which this passage ends sums up the developing narrative: God’s people have launched out in faith on a great voyage, yet not all is or will be smooth sailing.

³¹ There are many relevant passages, but Ex 20:24ff and 27:1ff bear most directly on the altar itself.

³² Various spelled; in Hebrew, חג הסוכות.

³³ The mosaic legislation can be found in Lev 23:34ff, Num 29:12ff, and Deut 16:13ff and 31:9ff.

³⁴ This interval is probably due to difficult circumstances, not limited zeal, given the care that this chapter as a whole sees the people taking in the whole process

E 3:1 *Israelites*: At the risk of overreading a term, “Israelites” rather than “Judeans” would seem to indicate that “this remnant is continuous with pre-exilic Israel” (Fyall, 71). The same point will, at any rate, be made less ambiguously at a later point (6:17).

E 3:3 Why were they afraid? Perhaps the location of the first temple, being a sacred site in the minds of many of the religiously-minded, might have seen syncretistic or pagan sacrifice, and in order to build and dedicate their temple the Jews “would [have to] remove the evidence of this” (Fyall, 58).³⁵ Alternatively or in addition, the Jews (correctly, as events would prove) anticipated resistance from neighboring people who would be jealous or suspicious of a resurgent Hebrew nation.

E 3:7 Paul’s use of his Roman citizenship (Ac 16:37, 22:25) is perhaps comparable.

E 3:8 *twenty years old or more*: This “was regarded as an age to take responsibility (cf. 1 Chr. 23:27; 2 Chr. 31:17). In Num. 8:24 it is twenty-five and in Num. 4:3, 23, 30 it is thirty” (Fensham, 64).

E 3:11 *faithful love* (חסד): The article on this important noun (in Hebrew, it is one word³⁶) by H.-J. Zobel, while problematic in some of its details, captures the contours of this important OT term well: “it is active, social, and enduring” (51). That is, it maintains a long-term relationship between two people (or between two nations, or between God and his people) in which the well-being of one or both parties is sought in tangible ways; it is more an action than a feeling, relational than individual, and more unlimited than limited. It is related on the one hand to the idea of a covenant, and on the other hand to the virtue of kindness. At points, the emphasis is more on the former, such that it is closely allied to ideas of faithfulness and reciprocity; at other moments, the emphasis is more on the latter, shading into notions of grace and benevolence.

E 3:11 Without getting too far afield, I might wonder whether the addition of “to Israel” to the usual formula here implied some degree of support for a doctrine of limited atonement. Of course, the truthfulness or falsity of such a doctrine would need to be primarily supported by more direct scriptural engagement with such ideas, and only secondarily backed up with texts like this one.

Ezra Chapter Four

Certain people (as the reader will learn, the Samaritans) approach the Jewish community, offering assistance in the work of rebuilding the temple. The author does not leave readers in suspense about their intentions: the Samaritans are “enemies of Judah and Benjamin” (v1). It is clear, then, that the offer (found in v2) is disingenuous. The nature of the scheme is not detailed—did the Samaritans intend to attack the Jews while their guard was down?—but the intention is harm, not help. The Jews respond resolutely. They alone (v3a) will build God’s temple. They add that they have a firm legal basis for their project, viz. the decree of Cyrus (v3b).

In response, however, the opposition does not cease, but merely changes shape, like some monster out of a myth. The Samaritans chip away at the Jews’ morale (v4) and at their support from the government (v5a). These varied forms of opposition would continue for many days to come (v5b).³⁷

At this point, the structure of EN becomes difficult for the modern reader to follow. Appendix 4

³⁵ Fyall cites Jer 41:5. That passage could refer to worship at the temple mount; or it could mean instead that some temple, intended as an interim measure or as a replacement, had been set up at or near Mizpah (such a practice is attested elsewhere).

³⁶ The fact that English translations of the Bible often have two words or a compound (“faithful love,” “lovingkindness,” etc.) reflects the lack of any exact equivalent of this word—even the idea—in English,

³⁷ Indeed, “right to the end of Nehemiah there is conflict. Nothing that is attempted for God will go unchallenged, and scarcely a tactic will be unexplored by the opposition” (Kidner, 53).

will discuss this issue. Suffice it to say here that the narrator, wishing to maintain focus on the opposition, uses a “flash-forward.”³⁸ The author strings together a pair of attempts to turn the Persian imperial administration against the Jews. First, when a new Persian emperor comes to the throne, and before he has had time to learn the intricacies of affairs in the Levant, the gentiles living in the land write some defamatory message to this king (v6). Then a wide range of political figures from the whole region, together with their allies and administrative apparatus, compose their own letter (vv7-10). They cleverly blend fact and fiction: Jerusalem did have something of a history of being cantankerous (though not toward the Persian empire), yet the threats that a rebuilt temple (or city) would pose to the empire are wildly exaggerated in this letter (vv11-6). Yet the king is alarmed by their bleak prognostications, and hears from the court memoranda what his paranoid ears expect to hear (vv17-23). (As discussed in Appendix 4, E 4:24 is best understood as resuming the storyline from 4:1-5 and as launching the narrative of 5:1ff.)

Seemingly, might has prevailed over right, and the fear of the king has snuffed out the faith of the people. But the story of EN is not yet over.

E 4:1-2 Some have thought that the author of EN is prejudicial to label the Samaritans “enemies” (v1) and the Jewish leadership is narrow-minded to refuse Samaritan aid (v2).³⁹ Certainly, tremendous friction would characterize the relationship between Jews and Samaritans (cf., e.g., Jn 4:9),⁴⁰ and many Jewish men would struggle with ethnocentrism (e.g., Gal 2:11-13), but ultimately these concerns are misplaced. In the first place, we seem to have the narrator’s evaluation here, not any single character in the story. In the second place, as mentioned above, the Samaritans’ rapid shift from a helpful posture to a hostile one shows that they never were truly disposed to be friends. In the third place, as in E 2:59ff, even Jewish men who could not demonstrate their genealogy could not participate in the temple service, so still less could these people lay claim to the rigorous requirements of the law of Moses.

E 4:1 The Samaritans (the first recorded use of the term is in 2 Ki 17:29) take their name from the territory of Samaria (which takes its name from its chief city by the same name); they descend from a mixture of surviving Hebrews from the shattered northern kingdom and gentiles brought in by the Assyrian overlords in order to dilute their cohesion. They blended Jewish and pagan religious practices, though over time they sought to adapt and adopt Jewish practice more thoroughly, though accepting only the Pentateuch (slightly corrupted, in order to support their view of themselves as the true Jews) as canonical. Their relationship with the Jews has been a tortured one, right down to the present day (a handful of survivors live in Israel and in the occupied West Bank).

E 4:2 *Let us build with you*: MacArthur (33) connects with passage with 2 Cor 11:14-15.

E 4:2 *worship*: Lit., “seek” (דָּרַשׁ).

E 4:2 *have been sacrificing*: The M text might be a very rare instance of emendation for reasons of orthodoxy, avoiding even the slightest hint of suggesting that the Samaritans actually did worship God.

E 4:4 *The people who were already in the land* (עַם הָאֶרֶץ): The context, together with the early date of EN,

³⁸ McConville (25): “The effect is similar to one that is produced in many modern stories and films by a ‘flashback’—except that here we have a flash-forward.”

³⁹ Lubeck (176n19) suggests that “enemies” here is “written from a *post facto* perspective, i.e. it is describing those who immediately after this exchange will become entrenched enemies.” This is not impossible, but it seems to me that the narrator would have worded things less ambiguously if this was his or her intent. The Samaritans’ immediate recourse to aggression (v4) casts doubt on any initial friendliness.

⁴⁰ The history between these groups is not as straightforward and the enmity is not as irrevocable as is sometimes depicted—see Knoppers (*passim*). Still, mutual recriminations were commonplace, and at times veered in murderous directions.

tells against reading this Hebrew phrase in the light of later usage (when it will mean “the uneducated,” “the boorish”).

E 4:5 *until the reign of King Darius*: If the reference is to Darius I, this statement cannot be about opposition in general, since opposition continued during the reigns of Ahasuerus and Artaxerxes (at least). Rather, the statement must have in mind specifically opposition to building the temple. This is probably what is meant—see E 6:13-15. Alternatively, the reference could be to Darius II or Darius III, one of whom is mentioned in N 12:22.

E 4:6 The beginning of the reign of any monarch was a busy time, as various people tested the new monarch’s knowledge and decisiveness. In this case, the Samaritans might have hoped that the new emperor would be too busy with other matters of state to verify their claims.

E 4:6 This terse account does not spell out the outcome. There are theories—plausible, though not incontrovertibly proven—that Persian troops actually ravaged the city during this time (see Steinmann, 224-225).

E 4:8 At this point the language switches from Hebrew to Aramaic.

E 4:8 Rehuma and Shimshai are seemingly Jewish names, but apparently their allegiance was altogether with the Persian imperial administration that had given them positions of power.

E 4:9-10 See on v8 regarding the identity of these people and places.

E 4:10 *great and illustrious Ashurbanipal*: “The obsequious tone of the enemies’ letter is typical of those who use flattery and attempt to ingratiate themselves to those in power in the hopes of accomplishing their own personal agendas” (MacArthur, 28). “It is further interesting to note that the horrors of deportation are glossed over and the event spoken of as if it were an administrative detail” (Fyall, 77).

E 4:12 *Jews*: The term “Jew” is in itself used as a pejorative (though on the lips of adversaries of God, it occasionally takes on a pejorative tint); at any rate, it should never be used that way by a Christian (Rom 11:28b). It derives from the tribal and place name Judah (and in this commentary, “Judeans” will be used as a synonym for variety), the most prominent tribe in the postexilic period, over time coming to mean any man or woman descended more or less exclusively from Jacob.

E 4:13 *they will not pay tribute, duty, or land tax*: MacArthur (28) dryly notes that the Samaritans are “speaking the king’s language” at this point.

E 4:23 Unmentioned at this point is that later in his career Artaxerxes, prompted by Nehemiah, will change his mind about the walls of Jerusalem (N 2:1ff).

E 4:24 *Now the construction of God’s house in Jerusalem had stopped*: If literalness of translation is a concern, the CSB translation of the first part of this verse is problematic: it would be at best unusual to render בָּאֵדִין in this way, and the Hebrew paragraphing suggests that v24, while deserving of special attention in some ways, stands in closer relation to chapter 4 than to chapter 5. Better would be a rendering like “Then the construction of God’s house in Jerusalem stopped.” The CSB can be understood, however, as a broad paraphrase, replacing the narrative style of the original Aramaic with an English style more readily approachable by native users of English.

E 4:24 *and remained at a standstill until the second year of the reign of King Darius of Persia*: The CSB heading before this verse should not be missed: although v24 obviously follows v23, it is resuming an

earlier timeline (the Darius of v24 comes *before* the Artaxerxes of v23!).

Ezra Chapter Five

God sends two prophets, Haggai and Zechariah, to speak to the people (v1). The style and length of their addresses differs significantly. Haggai addresses the people briefly, mixing probing questions around spiritual priorities with soaring promises of a glorious future. Zechariah speaks at greater length, narrating vivid scenes of God's providence and watchfulness and foretelling coming events of judgment and restoration. But the two prophetic voices are really one: God is still God, and his name must be honored with the rebuilding of his temple. The people (perhaps only at the prompting of their leaders, as role of Zerubbabel and Jeshua is highlighted both here and in the book of Haggai) listen to this united prophetic voice, and, with the continued encouragement of Haggai and Zechariah resume the work (v2).

With a renewal of effort comes a renewal of pushback. A nearby governor, together with others, questions the legal basis for the Judeans' work (v3), going so far as to ask for the names of those doing the actual construction (v4)—information that no doubt would have been used against the Judeans, had it been granted. But this time God's people holds firm (v5b), insisting that the Persian emperor's word would be required to make them stop (on the meaning of "until" see the comment below). In a rare tipping of the hand by the understated narrator of EN, the Jewish elders' success is attributed directly to the watchful eye of God (v5a). God's providence can be hard to interpret, but there are times when his gracious intervention in our lives is undeniable and must be celebrated.⁴¹

The compiler of EN prizes careful documentation, something not out of place in narrating an era of nation building and of resistance to litigious foes. So (s)he relates in full the letter that Tattenai and the others sent to King Darius. This letter expresses alarm at the rapidly rising structure in Jerusalem. The skeptical Tattenai relates the Judeans' reply to him and his colleagues.

This embedded Judean letter supplies all pertinent details while charting a course between timidity and temerity. They self-identify from the opening words as servants of the universal God ("servants of the God of the heavens and earth")⁴² and link the temple project with one of the key moments of their national past (v11). Far from being self-assured, however, they frankly admit that the reason that the temple needs to be built again is that their ancestors provoked God to anger, leading to the destruction of the temple and to the deportation of the people (v12). The following verses (13-16) provide the essentials of how the Persian king Cyrus had specifically authorized the ongoing project.

Having reported the Judeans' words, Tattenai requests that the royal archives in Babylon be searched. It is just possible that for all his appeals to the king's sovereignty ("if it pleases the king... Let the king's decision be sent to us," v17), he tries to pull the wool over Darius' eyes by asking for a search of Babylon, when in fact the record of Cyrus' decree is in Ecbatana (6:2). But whether Tattenai was counting on a less-than-thorough search on the part of the imperial administrative apparatus, or whether he was simply unaware of which archive should be consulted, it seems clear that Tattenai is hoping that the authorization will not be found. Much more malevolent, and even more misguided, are the machinations of Satan in his attempts to smear God's children with a record of sin (Rev 12:10). God will accept no charge against his chosen ones, for Christ has died once for all, and he unendingly lives to declare that we have the right to be called God's children (Rom 8:31ff).

E 5:2 Jeshua: Cf. on 2:2.

E 5:2 helping (מסעדין): This could mean that the prophets were not afraid to get their hands dirty helping with the physical aspects of this large building project. It is also quite possible that what is meant is "prophetic help that came in the form of messages from God" (Roberts, 91), i.e. prophetic instruction and exhortation.

⁴¹ Thomas expounds on this theme at length.

⁴² The words "and earth" here help to underscore the universal dimension. Cf. the comments on 1:2.

E 5:3 *Tattentai*: A man known from extrabiblical sources responsible for the western area (Steinmann, 253).

E 5:3 *Shethat-bozenai*: This “may be an Iranian name,” and he might have been known to the Elephantine community (Steinmann, 253). Both men, it would seem, were prominent and important.

E 5:5 *But God was watching over the Jewish elders*: As the CSB footnote indicates, this is more lit., “But the eye of their God was over the Jewish elders” (ועין אלההם הות על שבי יהודיא). As Shepherd and Wright note (25), this imagery has significant associations with the temple (Jer 24:6, 2 Chr 7:16). And as they also note the same page, this might be a light jibe at the “eyes and ears of the king,” informants regularly sent out by the Persian emperor to discover the facts on the ground: Darius could only see and do so much, while God is all-seeing and all-powerful.

E 5:5 *These men wouldn't stop until a report was sent to Darius, so that they could receive written instructions about this matter*: Does this mean that the building did not stop until Tattenai sent a letter (which he did), or that the building was not to stop until the king said that it must (which he did not)? The Aramaic could be understood either way, but the tenor of this passage, together with 6:14, seems to imply that the Judeans would not stop without definitive instructions from the throne. The hesitation from Tattenai and the others “may be due to uncertainty as to what to expect of the new Persian king” (Fensham, 80).

E 5:6 *text*: This is probably an accurate rendering of this word, which seems to be an Iranian technical term for “copy” (see Noonan, 184-185).

E 5:7 *all greetings* (שלמא כלא): Lit., “complete peace” (i.e., “heart well-wishes,” “all the best”).

E 5:8 *the house of the great God* (בית אלהא רבא): Why would an enemy of the temple project describe Yahweh as “great” to the Persian king? One approach would be to suggest that the word “great” here is not Tattenai’s, but rather has been added by the narrator as an indication of his own feelings, but v6 (“text”) probably rules out this interpretation. The narrator of EN does not seem squeamish about representing what the opponents were saying and doing. Another approach is to render the Aramaic here differently: Harrington (170), while preferring the usual translation, notes that it could alternatively be rendered (with Young’s Literal Translation) “the great house of God.” But this would be unusual phraseology as far as I am aware, while the Aramaic phrase “the great God” seems to have been in the air at the time, being found on both pagan (see Cowley, 183) and believing (Dan 2:25) lips; there is an Akkadian equivalent (Tawil, 437b), and the Hebrew equivalent will occur later in this book (N 8:6; also Ps 95:3, later to be echoed in Tit 2:13). A frequently offered proposal is the idea (Fyall, 84; Kidner, 61; Steinmann, 264) that the reference in “the great God” is to the chief deity of the land. In the ancient world, a city or region would often have a particular deity most closely associated with that locale (though in no way excluding the worship of other gods). This is possible, but to my knowledge there is no clear evidence elsewhere of רב meaning “chief” in precisely this sense elsewhere. For that reason, Fensham’s (82) less specific formulation that “it may have been a token of reverence for the God of this territory” might be preferable. As a governor Tattenai would have been fully aware of the imperial policy of honoring local deities, and he wants to make it clear that he is not objecting to that policy. Instead, Tattenai’s strategy is to represent the Jews as undermining Darius’ political authority by building without his authorization.

E 5:11 *a great king*: Solomon (1 Ki 7:13ff).

E 5:12 *a Chaldean*: At times this refers to a specific ethnic group, at times to a vocation, and at times to the Babylonians more broadly.

Ezra Chapter Six

Taking up the request of Tattenai and the others, King Darius searches Babylon for documentation of the Jews' claim of imperial authorization to rebuild the temple. He is unsuccessful (v1), but God's providence does not allow the emperor to be deterred. Ecbatana turns out to be housing the key document (v2): the Jews have indeed been authorized to build the temple (vv3-4a); and not only this, but the empire, specifically Tattenai's own region, will fund the project (vv4b-5).

Darius seems to be fully aware of Tattenai's bad intentions (v6), and is quite clear in mandating that Cyrus' decree be followed to the letter (vv7-10). And in order to make himself perfectly clear, Darius issues a new directive, threatening violent imperial and divine judgment on those who fail to obey, together with lasting ignominy (v11-12). In speaking of Yahweh's judgment of those who would interfere with the functioning of his house, Darius speaks truer than he knows: while God would one day allow the building that the Jews erected in Jerusalem to burn, he would never tolerate attempts to destroy his dwelling place among his people (1 Cor 3:17).

Thoroughly chastened, Tattenai and the others assist the Jews (v13), who with the continued encouragement of the prophets Haggai and Zechariah bring the project to its completion (vv14-15).

Fittingly, the Jews hold a festival dedicating the new temple (v16). The number of animals sacrificed is far from paltry, though—owing no doubt to their own small numbers and weak economic situation—not large in absolute numbers. The narrator calls particular attention to the number “twelve” as representing each of the tribes of Israel (v17). This conscious symbolism casts a glance back at the dedication of the tabernacle of Aaron (Num 7:87), and it also stakes out a vision for the future of the people: those dedicating the rebuilt temple⁴³ understand themselves not merely as members of the tribe of Judah or of the tribe of Levi, but as evidencing God's continuing presence with his people as a whole.⁴⁴ In the same vein of forward-looking reading of the Pentateuch, the people reinstitute the priestly and levitical polity described there (v18).

Festivity follows festivity: the feast of Passover, which, to summarize, in ancient times⁴⁵ involved a seven day period bracketed by assemblies at Jerusalem and culminating in the killing and eating of the sacrificial lamb (with unleavened bread and bitter herbs), all in commemoration of the exodus from Egypt.⁴⁶ This observation of the Passover must have been especially poignant, as the people were experiencing a kind of second exodus (from Persia in this case).⁴⁷

Joy unites both festivals (vv16, 22). A new section of the book will commence at 7:1, so it is notable that at this turning point the editor of EN leaves readers with the ideas of joy and Yahweh's ongoing work on his people's behalf.⁴⁸

E 6:17 “The participants of the dedication are described as Israelites and not as Jews” (Fensham, 93). They are not merely the survivors of the primarily Judahite state eliminated by the Babylonians, but the authorized representatives, the seed of the elect remnant, of God's people.

⁴³ This is clearly the narrator's assessment as well—see the beginning of v21.

⁴⁴ “This is a celebration by... the whole people of God, and as such looks back to the great celebration of Solomon's time and forward to the great multitude whom no one can count before the throne of God” (Fyall, 93).

⁴⁵ In ancient times (later there would be much adjustment to and elaboration of the Passover feast in mainstream Judaism).

⁴⁶ The primary texts are Ex 12:1ff, Lev 23:5-8, Dt 16:1ff.

⁴⁷ MacArthur (vii) observes, “The Jews' return from the Babylonian captivity seemed like a second Exodus, sovereignly patterned in some ways after Israel's first redemption from Egyptian bondage. The return trip from Babylon involved activities similar to those of the original Exodus: (1) the rebuilding of the temple and the city walls; (2) the reinstitution of the law, which made Zerubbabel, Ezra, and Nehemiah, collectively seem like a second Moses; (3) the challenge of the local enemies; and (4) the people's temptation to intermarry with non-Jew, resulting in idolatry.”

⁴⁸ See further Appendix 1.

E 6:19: At this point the language switches back to Hebrew (until 7:12); the focus in the section will be less on the flow of correspondence and more on the internal affairs of the Jewish community.

E 6:21 This verse “indicates that anyone who joined the covenantal community out of loyalty to Yahweh could partake of the covenant meal. This allowance maintained the original policy in Exodus 12:48-49” (Ulrich, 33).

E 6:22 *the Assyrian king:* Why is the Persian king referred to this way? In Mesopotamia, there was a long tradition of warriors from one area or another conquering the ancient urban centers from the outside, then claiming that somehow they were the legitimate heirs. So, this might be a reference to the putative continuity between the Persian throne and the Assyrian throne that (through Babylonian mediation) they absorbed. Steinmann (274) argues in essence that a contrast is being made between the pagan king who settled foreigners in the land of Israel (2 Kings 17:24ff) and this pagan king (Darius) who countermanded the gentiles in the land and allowed the temple of Yahweh to be rebuilt. This seems to be a lot to read into these words, but this might be on the right track (cf. N 9:32, cited in Steinmann, 275).

Ezra Chapter Seven

Here and seemingly for the next few chapters, the author of EN seems to make use of Ezra’s memoirs. In a book full of documentation, it is no surprise that this section kicks (vv1-15) off with Ezra’s credentials. As a priest, it is crucial that he can trace his lineage, and indeed he can, all the way back to Aaron’s son Eleazar—and through Saraiah, the chief priest at the beginning of the exile (2 Ki 25:18), no less.

Not only is Ezra a priest, but he is also a scribe, and a skilled and dedicated one at that (vv6a, 10). God’s providence allows Ezra’s planning and networking to give a real boost to the Judean community (vv6b-7).⁴⁹ Again due to God’s favor,⁵⁰ he arrives in a timely manner (vv8-9), the king’s endorsement in hand (v11). Artaxerxes’ letter gives Ezra permission to ensure conformity to Yahweh’s law in Jerusalem (vv12-14), and to use imperial funds and freewill offerings to pay for the temple revitalization (vv15-20). Furthermore, within certain (generous) bounds, the provincial authorities are to underwrite Ezra’s project (vv21-23), no taxation of the temple operations being permitted (v24). The letter closes with permission for Ezra to set up a judicial system in the whole area that accords with mosaic prescriptions (v25), with violators subsequent to imperial sanction (v26).

Speaking in his own voice,⁵¹ Ezra, gives glory to God for his providential work as his mission gets underway (vv27-28). Ezra, as we will see, is hardly a perfect leader, but nonetheless he goes a long way in modeling what leadership in the church should look like. Most likely, his life would have been more comfortable if he had stayed in Babylon, but he makes the journey to a struggling area; he makes it his mission both to understand and to apply the Scriptures; and, as noted, he gives glory to God.

E 7:1-6 Steinmann (286-287), noting the longer genealogical list found in 1 Chron 6:7-10, suggests that this list would have matched the longer one, and that a copyist accidentally skipped over part of the list as he was working on EN. But even then the list would seemingly not be complete, meaning either that the list is selective or that a separate textual error occurred (Steinmann, 287). It seems simplest to suppose that EN is giving only highlights of Ezra’s genealogy.

E 7:7 The language switches back from Aramaic to Hebrew here.

⁴⁹ In Ezra “we have no cloistered scholar nor a shallow activist; we have a man deeply schooled in the word of God who is also a man of planning and strategy. This is a good model for all of us who work for the kingdom of God” (Fyall, 102).

⁵⁰ Coincidentally or not, Ezra’s name means “help [from God].”

⁵¹ It is normal in Hebrew narrative to switch between grammatical persons, as Ezra does here, using first the third person (vv1ff.) and then the first person (vv2-28).

E 7:9 The word *journey* (מעלה) here is literally, “going up, ascent.” Hutchinson, though appropriately cautious, suggests that the “going up” language around Ezra’s journey to Jerusalem (see also v6) suggests that the psalms of ascent (Pss 120-134) refer not to regular visits to Jerusalem for festivals, but to the return to Jerusalem from captivity. Davidic (122, 124, 131, 132, 133) and solomonic (127) authorship of some of those psalms is not a fatal objection (cf. Ac 2:30).

E 7:10 “All three [of Ezra’s goals] are essential to godly leadership: the study of God’s word, obedience to God’s word, and the teaching of God’s word” (Betts, 136; he goes on to sketch some of the problems that arise from neglecting any one of these areas).

E 7:12 At this point the language is Aramaic again (Hebrew takes over permanently at v27).

E 7:25 *God’s wisdom that you possess* (כחכמת אלהך די בידך): More lit., “the wisdom of your god that you possess.” Artaxerxes recognizes Yahweh to be Ezra’s object of worship, and believes that Yahweh deserves respect and possesses (some measure of) sovereignty over Judea, but the Persian monarch does not think that Yahweh is the ruler of the universe.

Ezra Chapter Eight

Continuing the documentary predilections of this book, Ezra carefully records the people who came with him to the land of Israel (vv1-14). Even before Ezra completes his journey, however, he encounters signs of troubled waters ahead: three days of searching at the first major stopping point fails to find even one Levite (v15). Ezra ends up broadening his search (vv6-17), and, with help, finds some of the men he is looking for (vv18-20)—not many, but a start.

There is another matter for concern, namely, safety for the journey (v21b). The group’s vulnerability stems from Ezra’s feeling that asking the king for troops for protection would have implied a lack of trust in Yahweh (v22). It is questionable whether Ezra should have spoken to the king in that way, putting constraints on God’s behavior (Dt 6:16).⁵² Well-meaning Christians sometimes get out ahead of the Lord, asserting that he will do this or that miraculous thing, when he has not necessarily promised to do so. At any rate, Ezra leads the people in fasting and praying (vv21a, 23a), and, whether Ezra’s words to the king were a bit presumptive or not, God is gracious to them (v23b).

Next, Ezra makes careful arrangements for bringing the imperial funds and freewill offerings designated for the temple project safely to Jerusalem. Paul will face a similar situation later on, and similarly model the care which financial matters require (2 Cor 8:1ff).

At long last, the journey is complete (vv31a, 32a), Ezra and his group can rest (v32b), and then the temple offering can be taken care of, again in a conscientious and thorough manner (vv33-34, v36). God’s kindness, Ezra stresses, is responsible for the success of the journey (v31b). The group offers a sacrifice to God, and—as is particularly evident from the number of bulls and goats offered (twelve in both cases)—it is clear that they view their success not in isolation, but as the success of the whole people of God, “all Israel” (v35; cf. 6:17). Perhaps spurred on the words of the prophets (e.g., Jer 3:18, Ezek 37:16ff), they recognize that the destruction and dispersion of the Northern Kingdom by the Assyrians two centuries ago had not thwarted Yahweh’s plans to be the savior of his whole people.⁵³ Ezra and the others could hardly, however, have anticipated the form that God’s salvation of his people would take (Mat 1:18-21).

Ezra also did not anticipate the storm that was on his own horizon.

E 8:1 *Babylon*: It is difficult to know whether he means the city or the region dominated by it.

⁵² Nehemiah’s journey to Judea is protected by an armed guard (2:9), though admittedly the king might have insisted on protection for his cupbearer.

⁵³ Leslie Allen, in his commentary on 1-2 Chronicles, makes similar observations in a number of places. Cf. also Thompson, 33-35.

E 8:2-14 “Ezra never allows us to forget that there are real people involved here at every stage (as we have already seen in ch. 2) and that each, named and unnamed, was a living person who took this risk” (Fyall, 115).

E 8:15 *Ahava* (אהוּאָ): A place name, not to be confused with the Hebrew word for “love” (אהבה).

E 8:15 In our day, there seems to be an increasing lack of pastors to lead local congregations. Seeing that for NT believers the qualifications are not bloodline but character (1 Tim 3:1ff, Tit 1:5ff), there should not (ordinarily) be such a deficit. My suspicion is that much of this is a result of overly high expectations on the one hand (pastors are asked to be highly educated, highly extroverted, highly experienced, very youthful, having happy families and somehow simultaneously endless amounts of time to spend outside the home, etc.) and low support on the other hand (pastors often feel like they have no true friends, little room for error or downtime, nowhere to turn to for help and advice, etc.).

Ezra Chapter Nine

At this point Ezra is approached with a problem: the Jews have been intermarrying with gentile people in the lands who, it is reported, have been marrying gentiles, and this with those who should have been setting a good example leading the way (vv1-2). Now, it is not so clear that marrying gentiles was in all cases wrong, as the leaders imply to Ezra (see the comments on vv1-2 below), but the danger involved in complacency toward the “detestable practices” (v1) of the nations is real. In fact, the risk is that the people will repeat precisely the pattern that led to the exile in the first place—having just returned from Babylon, will the Jewish people immediately plunge into the sinful practices of the nations and again be liable to the severest of judgment?

So it is that Ezra is “devastated” (v3). He is unable to speak until evening (v4), then, clothes torn in grief, he prays to God (v5), admitting national guilt and begging that the “brief moment” of God’s “grace” that they have experienced in returning to the land (v8) will not be end.

E 9:1-2 Ex 34:11ff prescribes the expulsion from the promised land of the Amorite, Canaanite, Hittite, Perizzite, Hivite, and Jebusite nations, and proscribes intermarriage with them; Dt 7:1ff reaffirms these points, adding the Girgashites to the list of forbidden nations. Both passages make the point that if the Israelites fail to follow these commands, the inevitable result will be that the Hebrews will be drawn into the nations’ idolatry and wickedness (which, it must be stressed, included not only the worship of false gods but such practices as the killing of infants). One of the important questions here is whether the lists of nations mentioned in these two passages (and cf. further Dt 20:17, which lists the same nations as in Ex 34, but in a different order) are comprehensive, or only representative samples. If the latter, the leaders of E 9:1ff are seemingly on solid ground when they expand the list to include Ammonites, Moabites, and Egyptians. On the one hand, the variability of the three lists just mentioned, together with other comparable nations lists in the Pentateuch, might suggest that no one list is meant to be taken as comprehensive. On the other hand, as Craige (178n6) points out, “Hebrew law does not prohibit mixed marriages outright... see Deut. 21:10-14.” As the same writer goes on to note (178-179) with regard to Dt 7:1ff, “the specific prohibition probably has in mind the forging of political treaties by means of marriage.” Furthermore, all three additions of the leaders in E 9:1ff—the Ammonites, the Moabites, and the Egyptians—are nations which see different treatment in Dt 23:4ff. Though “the tenth generation” in v4 three is often taken to be a perpetual ban (see, e.g., Craige, 297), the words “may ever” would seem to be firmly excluding those ten generations specifically (otherwise “may ever” would potentially be redundant), and the qualification “in the third generation” regarding Egyptians in v8 implies that the tenth generation regarding Ammonites and Moabites is meant literally, not figuratively. If so, the time element for those two people groups would have long since expired (so, e.g., Lubeck, 179-180). And the

Egyptians are to be well thought of (v7).⁵⁴ Then there are important cases of marriages with gentiles recorded in the OT, most notably Boaz's marriage to Ruth, a Moabite.⁵⁵ Most likely, the nation lists in Ex 34:11ff, etc. are not meant to be comprehensive in themselves, but neither are they meant to apply equally to every gentile people everywhere. God was in the Hebrew invasion of Canaan under Joshua judging specific nations, and he gave regulations concerning certain other nations, but not banning all marriages outside the Hebrew people. In short, the leaders here are on shaky ground in their expansive application of the law.

E 9:2 Possibly there is an early example of tendentious exegesis—such as would often characterize mainstream Judaism in late antiquity and beyond—here, Shecaniah using the verbal root ער"ב to describe (what he sees as) what has happened to the noun זרע.

E 9:3 Shepherd and Wright (41) suggest that Ezra plucks his hair to avoid the prohibition (Dt 14:1) against shaving.

E 9:9 The term חסד here seems to shade into the domain of חן, arguably anticipating later Hebrew usage. On the former term in general, see on 3:11 above.

E 9:11-12 There is no passage in the prophets that matches Ezra's quotation. The wording is more in line with what one might see in Deuteronomy, though again there is no exact match. Either he is summarizing what he believes the tenor of the prophets to be, or counting Moses as one of the prophets; either way, I'm not sure that he is on point with regard to the absolute impermissibility of intermarriage (see above on vv1-2), but quite on track with regard to the pervasiveness and perniciousness of sin in this world.

Ezra Chapter Ten

Ezra continues in abject despair and tearful confession (cf. 9:3ff and on v6 below), many people whose spirits resonate with his instinctively gather to him, weeping (10:1). Then a man named Shechaniah comes up with a radical proposal:⁵⁶ mass divorce (vv2-4). Even granting, for the sake of argument at least, that the leaders are right to see marriage between Jews and gentiles as intrinsically unlawful, divorce is never prescribed by God in the law of God or by prophetic pronouncement, not even in cases of polygamy. So I think that Shechaniah has gone too far,⁵⁷ and indeed, I suspect that we are seeing in this passage the first steps in a process that would lead to the vast, misguided, and burdensome expansion of the law that would so infuriate Jesus.⁵⁸

In any case, Ezra accepts the proposal (v5), though he does not seem confident in the outcome (v6). By decree (v7), and under the threat of losing all their possessions (v8), the people, shivering in rain (v9b), assembles outside the temple (v9a) to hear Ezra's accusation (v10) and directive (v11). The plan is

⁵⁴ In another connection, Arnold (434) notes such pentateuchal nation lists "never include Egyptians."

⁵⁵ Hubbard (165) notes that Boaz's words in 2:11 bring to mind "the ancient migration of Abram and Sarah (Gen. 12:1-5). They also left familiar roots for an unknown land. If the narrator intentionally sounded this echo, then he viewed Ruth in a light similar to Israel's view of Abram and Sarah. He implied a continuity between them, as if this foreigner might emerge as some sort of matriarch in Israel on a par with Sarah." To be clear, it is hard to be certain that the narrator of Ruth fully endorses Boaz's words or actions, though it is hard to escape the impression, at least in general terms.

⁵⁶ It is hard to know how significant this is, but there does seem to be a certain passiveness in Ezra.

⁵⁷ See Appendix 6 for further discussion.

⁵⁸ This is a serious charge to make, and while I stand by it, an aspect "of Ezra 10 that deserves careful consideration is the people's hunger for righteousness. Whether or not we agree with their solution, we see in Ezra, Shechaniah, and others a heartfelt desire to what is right" (155). Similarly, Thomas calls on churches to be respectful toward leaders who have to wrestle with difficult issues (193-195). I think he is overstating his case when he says with reference to Ezra and the others that it would be "churlish of us to second-guess their actions" (195), but his larger point stands: patience is a virtue, especially when controversy polarizes public discussion.

accepted (v12) by most (v15), granting that an extension of time is required to implement it (vv13-14, 16-17). The section concludes with a hall of shame, a list of the offending parties, or at least the most notable among them (vv18-44). However one assesses who is to blame and for what, it is a bleak day in Israel.

E 10:2 *Shecaniah... an Elamite*: It is unclear whether this means he was, or was related to, the men mentioned in 2:7 (so Steinman, 345), or, though Jewish, hailed from the region of Elam in Mesopotamia. Either way, he probably felt the sting of exile very personally.

E 10:6 “Although he appeared to accept Shechaniah’s ‘hope’ for Israel, it would seem that Ezra scarcely felt hopeful. His private mourning emphasizes the utter authenticity of his earlier display of grief. He had not grieved publicly merely to put on a show for the people, but, rather, that they might be drawn into a spirit of repentance also” (Roberts, 148).

The nature of his mourning might be inspired by Dt 9:18-19.

E 10:15 Possibly one of these men had married a gentile wife, based on the later list of names, but seemingly the other three had not.

Nehemiah Chapter One

At this point, approximately halfway through the book, the author/editor of EN shifts our attention back to Mesopotamia, where the book began.⁵⁹ There we find a man named Nehemiah, whose memoirs will drive the remainder of EN (v1).⁶⁰ He is the emperor's cupbearer (v11b), and therefore someone with a very important role,⁶¹ though by no means was he ever guaranteed a fair hearing from the Persian monarch (cf. Est 4:11). One of his siblings has apparently traveled to Judea. Returning to Mesopotamia with some Judeans, he visits Nehemiah, who asks them how things are going there (v2). The answer (v3) devastates Nehemiah (v4), who prays to Yahweh (v5ff).

Nehemiah’s prayer shows that he is a man who has immersed himself in Scripture:⁶² it is a pastiche of scriptural quotations and allusions. A more detailed summary of this will be presented in the comments below, but here three key passages can be mentioned: the prophecy of Moses (Dt 30:1ff), the prayer of Solomon (1 Kings 8:22ff), and the petition of the psalmist (106:47) that God would regather his repentant people from exile. The first passage comes from the foundational pronouncements of Israel’s covenant relationship with Yahweh, now, Nehemiah avers, being reaffirmed; the second from the dedication of the temple, now in the process (however halting) of being rebuilt; and the third from the believing call of the repentant community.

In confessing the sins of the people, Nehemiah does not pin the blame on others, but includes himself among the sinners (v7), as did Ezra in earlier days (E 9:6) and Daniel before him (9:5)—all three men apparently modeling themselves on ancient words (Ps 106:6). Only Jesus has known no sin (2 Cor 5:21), and leaders, like all believers (cf., Lk 11:4, 18:9-14), need to confess their failings regularly. Now, commentators frequently emphasize the fact that Nehemiah owns up to his own part in the long trail of sins, and implicitly or directly draw the conclusion that leaders ought to be willing to take responsibility for their part in troubles. This is true enough, but Nehemiah’s train of thought is probably focused more

⁵⁹ See the Preface and the Introduction on the fact that Ezra-Nehemiah is in reality a single book.

⁶⁰ See the Introduction on the prehistory of the book. To be clear, N 1:1-13:31 is probably excerpts from, rather than the whole of, Nehemiah’s memoirs; and the editor EN might have inserted some material here and there (chapters eight through ten most notably).

⁶¹ The occupant of the Persian throne faced constant danger of assassination, so “a most trusted individual had to fill the position of royal cupbearer” (Betts, 8). Down through the ages monarchs have often turned to foreigners to fill positions of this kind, since nonnative individuals lack blood ties to people who might form some realistic plan to seize power.

⁶² This trait of his is one of the traits he shares with Ezra (cf. E 7:10); and, occurring at one of the seams of the book and with reference to one of the major characters, it forms one of the major themes of EN (cf. further Appendix 1).

on the corporate rather than the individual aspect: he is part of a sinful nation. Every believer in God stands or falls based on his or her own relationship with God (Jer 31:29f, Rom 14:4), and the one who overcomes will receive a name known only to them and to God (Rev 2:17), but it is with a people—not merely a group of disconnected individuals—that God will dwell with forever (21:3).

At any rate, Nehemiah sees (vv10-11) in Ps 106 (vv1-5, 47) not only confession of sin but confidence of redemption; the God kept his promises in the days of Moses and of Zerubbabel will do so now. And so Nehemiah appeals to God, thinking specifically of his interactions with the king (“this man”). Nehemiah goes so far as to ask for success “today”—but, as it will turn out, he will need to wait.

N 1:1 *Susa*: This is the same city that sees the events described in the book of Esther (1:2). Those events happened early in the reign of Ahasuerus/Xerxes (v3), whereas Nehemiah memoirs pick up long into the reign of the following monarch, Artaxerxes; so whether Esther is someone Nehemiah had met is anyone’s guess.

N 1:2 *Hanani*: He turns up again 7:2, again in Judea and this time with more responsibility. There is a chance—though it is far from certain—that he is the same man who later attempted to bring the heterodox practices of the Jewish community of Elephantine into line with Scripture (see Steinmann, 387-388).

N 1:2 Why did Nehemiah not know the situation in Judea? Travel was difficult back then (even in the Persian empire), there was no news service outside closed channels of governmental communication, and Nehemiah (to judge from his reaction in 2:3) is hardly comfortable asking the emperor questions not directly related to his own line of work.

N 4:5-11 Here is a fuller (though still not comprehensive) list of passages Nehemiah has in mind as he prays. Quoting them here will hopefully not only illuminate Nehemiah’s prayer life, but partly show the wider arc in which the events of EN fit. Jon 1:9: “He answered them, ‘I’m a Hebrew. I worship the Lord, the God of the heavens, who made the sea and the dry land.’” Ex 34:6-7: “The Lord — the Lord is a compassionate and gracious God, slow to anger and abounding in faithful love and truth, maintaining faithful love to a thousand generations, forgiving iniquity, rebellion, and sin.” 1 Ki 8:52, 59: “May your eyes be open to your servant’s petition and to the petition of your people Israel, listening to them whenever they call to you... May my words with which I have made my petition before the Lord be near the Lord our God day and night. May he uphold his servant’s cause and the cause of his people Israel, as each day requires.” Ps 41:4: “I said, ‘Lord, be gracious to me; heal me, for I have sinned against you.’” Ps 106:6: “Both we and our ancestors have sinned; we have done wrong and have acted wickedly.” Dt 4:26-31: “I call heaven and earth as witnesses against you today that you will quickly perish from the land you are about to cross the Jordan to possess. You will not live long there, but you will certainly be destroyed. The Lord will scatter you among the peoples, and you will be reduced to a few survivors among the nations where the Lord your God will drive you. There you will worship man-made gods of wood and stone, which cannot see, hear, eat, or smell. But from there, you will search for the Lord your God, and you will find him when you seek him with all your heart and all your soul. When you are in distress and all these things have happened to you, in the future you will return to the Lord your God and obey him. He will not leave you, destroy you, or forget the covenant with your ancestors that he swore to them by oath, because the Lord your God is a compassionate God.” Dt 30:1-4 “When all these things happen to you — the blessings and curses I have set before you — and you come to your senses while you are in all the nations where the Lord your God has driven you, and you and your children return to the Lord your God and obey him with all your heart and all your soul by doing everything I am commanding you today, then he will restore your fortunes, have compassion on you, and gather you again from all the peoples where the Lord your God has scattered you. Even if your exiles are at the farthest horizon, he will gather you and bring you back from there.” Dt 12:8-12 “You are not to do as we are doing here today; everyone is doing whatever seems right in his own sight... When you cross the Jordan and live in the land the Lord your God is giving you to inherit, and he gives you rest from all the enemies around you and you

live in security, then the Lord your God will choose the place to have his name dwell. Bring there everything I command you: your burnt offerings, sacrifices, offerings of the tenth, personal contributions, and all your choice offerings you vow to the Lord. You will rejoice before the Lord your God — you, your sons and daughters, your male and female slaves, and the Levite who is within your city gates, since he has no portion or inheritance among you.” Ps 100:3: “He made us, and we are his —his people, the sheep of his pasture.” Ex 32:11 “But Moses sought the favor of the Lord his God: ‘Lord, why does your anger burn against your people you brought out of the land of Egypt with great power and a strong hand?’”

N 1:11 *this man*: It is often stated that in the Bible referring to someone as “this man,” “this person,” etc., has a contemptuous air. But this is not necessarily the case (cf., e.g., Lk 14:9). In certain cases, the indirectness of “this man” can have that effect, but it is context-dependent. As will be seen in the next chapter, Nehemiah was afraid of the Persian king. Whether he was also contemptuous of him is possible—even probable, at least as regards Artaxerxes’ religious views—but not certain.

Nehemiah Chapter Two

Waiting for an answer to prayer can be difficult, and apparently it was in Nehemiah’s case; some months after the prayer recorded in chapter one, Nehemiah’s sorrow becomes obvious to the king (vv1-2). Nehemiah, asked what is troubling him, relates the “personal blow” (Kidner, 87) of his ancestral city lying in ruins (v3). Now, Artaxerxes had forbidden reconstruction in the past (E 4:17ff), so he might have taken offense, or—less ominously but still unhelpfully—have offered his cupbearer mere platitudes. Instead, he asks Nehemiah on the spot for a plan of action (v4a). Also on the spot, Nehemiah prays for wisdom (v4b). The king of heaven is never unavailable, even when we are in the presence of a king.

Nehemiah responds politely but directly: he wishes to go to Jerusalem to rebuild it (v5). He is prepared to offer details on how long it will take and what it will involve, and the king is agreeable to these terms (vv6-8a). Nehemiah, like Ezra (e.g., E 7:27f), ascribes these good results to God’s favorable providence (v8b).

Nehemiah sets out on his way, protected by an imperial escort (v9). He must have been overjoyed—but not everyone shared this opinion (v10).

After a bit of rest (v11), Nehemiah sets out to see the situation of the walls for himself, being discreet about it (vv12-16). Having sized things up, he addresses the leaders to the people, making the case for a rebuilding project, pointing to God’s grace as seen in Artaxerxes’ reaction (vv17-18a). The people agree (v18b).

But as so often in EN, opposition in one form or another is always knocking at the door. Three local officials respond with mocking incredulity, tinged with more than a hint of malice (v19). Nehemiah’s reply is unequivocal: Jerusalem is God’s city, and God’s people will decide its fate. As it will turn out, these opponents will not go away quietly.

N 2:1 *During the month of Nisan*: Considering the sequence of months in the Jewish calendar,⁶³ and comparing 1:1 with 2:1, it becomes clear that “the twentieth year” in 1:1 cannot mean the twentieth year of Artaxerxes’ reign—perhaps it is the twentieth year of Nehemiah’s life, or the twentieth year of his career (Steimann, 385-386). The length of time between Nehemiah’s prayer and his conversation with the king, then, is uncertain, but at least the better part of a year. It is unclear whether the lengthy interval is due to Nehemiah’s possibly being only one of several cupbearers on rotation (so Steinmann, 399) or because it took the king a while to notice Nehemiah’s emotional state; either way, Nehemiah, like many saints before and since, had to wait on an answer to his prayer.

N 2:1 *when wine was set before him*: It is unclear whether this refers to the normal course of Nehemiah’s

⁶³ Nisan, Iyar, Sivan, Tammuz, Av, Elul, Tishrei, Cheshvan, Chislev, Tevet, Shevat, and Adar (English spellings vary).

duties a cupbearer (so, e.g., Steinman, 399) or to a festival (so, e.g., Fensham, 158-159).

N 2:2 *I was overwhelmed with fear* (ואירא הרבה מאד): This rendered by the CSB is potentially a bit misleading, if it is taken to mean that Nehemiah is totally paralyzed by terror. His prayer and his bold words show that he is not mentally collapsing. Still, the Hebrew is stronger than the typical indications of fear, and it is safe to say that Nehemiah must have felt symptoms of acute stress.

Why is Nehemiah so afraid? Many suggestions have been made. One common idea is that Nehemiah was concerned that the king would think that his cupbearer was on edge because he was part of a treasonous scheme, but this seems unlikely, since Nehemiah's fear comes after the king says, "This is nothing but sadness of heart." Kidner's (87) suggestion, while a bit speculative, might nevertheless be hitting the nail on the head: "Now the moment has come, and if he mishandles it there will not be another." Other factors include the capriciousness of Persian throne in general and the specific difficulty that Jerusalem could have been a prickly subject for Artaxerxes—as Kidner (87) also notes, Nehemiah "will be asking the king to revise his policy" (cf. E 4:17-23).

N 2:3 As many commentators point out, Nehemiah is perhaps being tactful in not mentioning Jerusalem by name, though it could not have been or long remained a secret what city he was talking about.

N 2:6 We know from elsewhere that the queen's name was Damaspiia. The commonplace that women were extraordinarily powerful in the Persian court might have more to do with Greek misogyny (much of our information about the Persian comes filtered through Greek sources—that is, through writers who often bore much enmity toward Persia and at any rate had their own prejudices). Even so, it may be that Damaspiia's presence had a moderating influence on Artaxerxes. The details of who happened to be in the room at the time were providential.

N 2:10 On the identity of these men, see on v19 below.

N 2:13 *Serpent's Well* (עין התנין): The CSB footnote proposes an alternative rendering, "Dragon's Well." This is probably closer to the truth, as long as it is kept in mind that medieval European and modern cinematic dragons are not meant, but rather some sort of monstrous but real creature—possibly specifically a crocodile (perhaps Solomon had imported one from Egypt?); cf. Koehler and Baumgartner, 2: 1764.

N 2:19 Sanballat is a Babylonian name, but his being a Horonite might mean that he is from one of the Beth-horon towns along the Benjamin-Ephraim border. Certainty is probably unattainable,⁶⁴ but he might be Jewish, his father or grandfather having been renamed by the Babylonians when they overthrew the Southern Kingdom. Alternatively, he might be Samaritan,⁶⁵ mixed in ancestry and religious affiliation; or Babylonian, sent by the Persians to do government work in that area.

Similarly confusing is the case of Tobiah. Tobiah is a Jewish name ("Yahweh is good"), yet he is described as "an Ammonite official." Perhaps Judaism, or some syncretistic form of it, had reached Ammon,⁶⁶ but more likely this simply means that the Persian administration had assigned governance of Ammon to him, despite his own ethnicity (so Steinmann, 403; cf. 6:17-18).⁶⁷

Geshem was an Arabian⁶⁸ ruler whose son would go on to build a formidable power base in the region. "Although these local officials couch their challenge in defense of the Persian king, their real

⁶⁴ The study of names to determine ethnicity is a legitimate enterprise, but one to be undertaken with caution (Boardman, 149).

⁶⁵ Nehemiah's words in v20 are reminiscent of E 4:3, but cf. N 4:2, which seems to make a distinction between Sanballat and the Samaritans.

⁶⁶ Josephus reports that the Maccabees later forcibly converted some of the Idumeans to Judaism.

⁶⁷ He might well be connected to the Tobiad family, prominent in intertestamental times.

⁶⁸ This is a term which in ancient literature and (even more so) in modern discourse encompasses a rather large range of groups; on the term as used here, cf. Boardman, 148.

concern is undoubtedly the threat of Nehemiah to their own authority” (Harrington, 293).

Nehemiah Chapter Three

This chapter details the initial progress on repairing the walls, gates, and towers of Jerusalem. That the motivation for this work was primarily religious is shown by the repeated use (vv1-2) of the word “dedicate” (or “consecrate,” קדש). Dedication of these items was not something required by the law of Moses, yet clearly there was a sense that in rebuilding the city that bore God’s name the Jews were engaging in an act of worship.

Not everyone was enthusiastic, though: Nehemiah notes that some of the elites “did not lift a finger to help” (v5). A similar problem would afflict the people during Jesus’ ministry (Mat 23:4). It is vital for Christian leaders to be willing to work hard (Ac 20:34, 1 Cor 4:12, 1 Thes 2:9).

But in this chapter we see most of the people working hard, and indeed, even some people going beyond even their normal duties (v12): Shallum, though an official in the city, worked on the project; and his daughters, though women in the ancient world had many demanding tasks such as the preparing of food (not an easy thing in those days) and the making and cleaning of clothes, also helped. Women would also play a prominent role in Jesus’ ministry (e.g., Lk 8:2, 23:27) and beyond. The glory of God often calls men and women to go above and beyond.⁶⁹

N 3:32 What in typical English versions is 4:1-6 is in traditional Hebrew versification 3:33-38. This results in the versification systems being out of sync until 5:1.

Nehemiah Chapter Four

Human evil tends to plot a course from ridicule to subterfuge, and from subterfuge to violence. Sanballat and his allies, angry about the rebuilding of Jerusalem, at first mock and scorn the Jews (vv1-3), then plot together (vv7-8), and finally turn to violence to reach their goals (vv11-12). The religious leaders during Jesus’ ministry would follow a similar pattern. Nehemiah responds to each provocation with prayer (vv4-5, v9) and exhortations to faith (v14), together with precautionary measures (v13ff). The building continues (v6, v15), despite considerable discouragement (v10). This, too, is a pattern seen again and again: God’s people often feel downcast as they labor in the trenches, yet, almost unseens, the work of God continues, not even death itself putting a stop to the building of Christ’s Church (Mat 16:18).

The risks are so great that the builders need to have their weapons with them all the time. Nehemiah in particular seems to be under threat, requiring guards and constant vigilance. But in some ways, the greatest threats lie not on the blades of their enemies but within their own hearts, as the next chapter will show.

N 4:1 On the versification, see on 3:32.

N 4:3 The joke is that even a fox, which is a small animal that runs low to the group, would not notice the wall until it tripped, so pathetic is the Jewish rebuilding effort.

N 4:4-5 Imprecatory prayers are impassioned and impressionistic in their form, so not to be read too literally. They base themselves on the promises of God (Dt 10:17-18) with concern for the people of God (32:31-43). They are proportional (Ps 35:8) and provisional (Jer 18:5ff, 2 Sam 12:22). Being on this side of the cross of Christ gives us a fresh vantage point on both the justice (Rev 6:9ff) and generosity (Rom 8:31ff) of God—see esp. Rom 3:21-36.

⁶⁹Nehemiah’s memoirs do not draw attention to this point, but all this latent zeal was stirred to action only after he reminded them of the gracious providence of God (2:17-18). In our present age, when the real and potential abuses of leadership often lead to the (attempted) jettisoning of leadership altogether, it must be recognized that godly leadership has important functions in actualizing and channeling the energies of God’s people.

N 4:5 *angered* (הכעיס): Or, “antagonized,” “verbally abused,” “dispirited.”

N 4:7 “One might surmise that if one prays and continues to faithfully and obediently serve the Lord, then circumstances in life will improve. But Nehemiah 4:7-8 indicates there are times when believers do the right things in the face of opposition and [yet] that opposition grows and intensifies... when we continue to faithfully serve Christ in the midst of opposition, sometimes matters get much more difficult before they get better” (Betts, 73).

N 4:14 *Our God will fight for us*: The context makes clear that Nehemiah is not envisioning inaction on their part (their weapons are at hand, horns ready to be blown for reinforcements). Faith in God sometimes means resting, but often it is what pushes God’s people on to faithful labor.

N 4:15 *God had frustrated it*: “Nehemiah never lost sight of the fact that God was in control of all events. The plot was not foiled because the Jews had learned about it, nor because of their readiness to fight back, but because God prevented it” (MacArthur, 105).

Nehemiah Chapter Five

At this point a problem that had apparently escaped Nehemiah’s notice under the pressure of the building project and the threat of attack, but one which had been percolating for some time: with the population growing and the imperial taxes heavy, many had become impoverished, and, so far from helping, the better-off in Judea had made things worse by taking children (especially girls) as slaves and charging crushing interest rates (vv1-5). The law of Moses forbade charging interest to fellow Jews (Dt 23:19f), especially when those asking for loans were in dire financial straits (Lev 23:35ff). Ancient Israel was not particularly interested in a free market economy; more to the point, those who by God’s grace had been saved from the sting of slavery in Egypt out not to put each other under the same yoke of bondage, but to seek wellbeing for all God’s people—hence Nehemiah’s fury (v6).

Nehemiah’s considered course of action is to announce to the nobles and officials the nature of their guilt (v7), perhaps so as not to blindside them, and then to call a public meeting (v8). He calls out their behavior, and requires them to return what they have wrongly taken (vv9-11). They agree to do this (v12a). Not content with a mere promise, Nehemiah requires an oath administered by the priests (vv12b-13).

On the topic of oppression, Nehemiah notes that the Persian occupation had long taxed the people excessively; but he set out to break that cycle, using of course the funds provided for administration, but only as necessary, and minimizing the burden on the people (vv14-18).

Nehemiah asks God to remember his good deed (v19). There is no need to read this cynically; Nehemiah apparently wrote this in his memoirs, and at any rate is simply asking God to be true to his nature (Ps 18:20, 19:11, 48:11, etc.). Jesus himself will ask God to glorify him in order that he might glorify the Father (Jn 17:1).

N 5:6 Nehemiah is angry, but his anger is under his control and is directed at genuine problems of unrighteousness, rather than his own preferences (see Betts, 86-89 for fairly extensive discussion).

N 5:7 *After seriously considering the matter* (וימלך לבי עלי): The Hebrew does not necessarily imply that Nehemiah took a long time mulling things over or that the situation was difficult for him to assess. Rather, he took his own counsel, privately weighing matters—probably weighing how to approach the problem.

Nehemiah Chapter Six

The memoirs return to the subject of external opposition. Direct attacks on the city are no longer feasible (v1), so an attempt is made to lure Nehemiah away in order to do away with him (v2). Nehemiah sidesteps this (v3), repeatedly (v4). Sanballat then ups the ante, by publicly (sending a man with “an open letter”) voicing the idea that Nehemiah is plotting to be king (vv5-7). Nehemiah denies this, and continues

working, once more praying for God's enablement (vv8-9).

Beset by foes outside the walls, Nehemiah is again surprised to find foes within those walls. He approaches the prophet Shemaiah, but Shemaiah's prophecy calls for something unlawful, viz. to enter the temple sanctuary (v10).⁷⁰ Anticipating Paul's exhortation to test everything and abstain from the evil (1 Thes 5:20-22), Nehemiah says that he, not being a Levite, cannot enter (v11), and notes to himself that Shemaiah is acting as a false prophet, hired to sully Nehemiah's reputation (vv12-13). And this incident was not an isolated one,⁷¹ other false prophet(esse)s seeking to cause Nehemiah trouble—so, once again, Nehemiah can only look upward to God (v14).

And God has continued to watch over the city. In fifty-two days, few in number but full of trial, the walls have been repaired (v15). The enemies who tried so hard to discourage the Jews are now themselves discouraged (v16a), having seen the finger of God (v16b). All the family connections and political machinations of Tobiah (vv17-18) had failed.

N 6:2 *the villages of the Ono Valley*: “The location described here was on the border of Nehemiah's territory next to Samaria and Ashdod, who were hostile neighbors and a full day's journey from Jerusalem” (Harrington, 335).

N 6:3 Why does not Nehemiah tip his hand that he knows about their murderous intentions? Perhaps it is because he cannot absolutely prove the existence of the plot, and making accusations against a recognized authority might be used by unfriendly elements within the Persian imperial administration as grounds for slowing or stopping Nehemiah's project.

N 6:10 *restricted to his house*: Perhaps he is unclean, or ill, or on some kind of probation but (at this moment) still respected by Nehemiah.

N 6:10 Shemaiah's words can be read as poetry (as does the CSB). Harrington suggests that “Shemaiah's proposal is dressed up as an oracle” (337).

N 6:14 “Multitudes have turned away from God and the people of God because of the misdeeds of so-called Christian leaders. It is a strong temptation to become disillusioned and quit serving the Lord because of ungodly laypeople and leaders in the community of faith, whether in Old Testament Israel or in the church today... We must not be surprised, disheartened, or cynical about Christ's church or serving him on account of sinful people, even if they are brothers or sisters in Christ” (Betts, 105).

N 8:7-8 Among those holding that this is not translation but explanation is Betts, who notes a pattern throughout the Bible that explanation is to accompany the reading of Scripture (135).

Nehemiah Chapter Seven

The safety of the city secured, Nehemiah can turn his attention to administration, particularly that of the temple grounds (v1). He understood that “the holy city was more than a city and a temple wall—it was also a *holy people* inhabiting the city” (Steinmann, 508 [emphasis his]). He put a particularly godly man in charge of the city, along with his brother, who had first communicated to him the needs of the city (1:2ff). To be sure, security was an ongoing concern (v3).

Also a concern was the slowness with which the Judean population was settling within the city limits—most evidently preferred (to put in modern terms) the suburbs, and beyond (v4). Accordingly, in a plan he ascribes to God's help, Nehemiah sets out to gather census information (v5ff), which will enable him to hold a lottery by which ten percent of the Judean population will be chosen to live in Jerusalem

⁷⁰ Only the Levites could enter (Num 18:7), others being forbidden entrance on pain of death.

⁷¹ Sad to say, the modern church can expect false teachers in its midst as well (Ac 20:29ff).

(11:1ff). The basis of this census is presented in the bulk of the present chapter.⁷²

Neh 7:7 *Mispereth* (מספרת): In Ezra 2:2, the spelling is “Mispar” (מספר), a minor variation within Hebrew.

N 7:72 As can be seen from the CSB layout, the verse break (verses not being original to the biblical text, but added by scholars much later for ease of reference) really ought to come at a different spot, since the second half of this verse kicks off the content of chapter eight.

N 7:72 *the seventh month*: “The seventh month was Tishri, which followed Elul, the month in which the wall was completed. This convocation took place just six days after the completion of the wall. The wall was completed on 25 Elul (Neh 6:15), that is, October 2, 445 BC. The date of the convocation was 1 Tishri, that is, October 8, 445 BC” (Steinmann, 509).

Nehemiah Chapter Eight

This book has done much to show the importance of leaders, but at times profound things emerge seemingly organically from the larger group. Assembling in Jerusalem, the people ask Ezra to bring them the law of Moses so that they can all hear it (v1). Ezra must have been pleased with this request, and reads for hours to all present from a specially-built platform (vv1-4). At the sight of the law of God open, the people respond with a sign of respect (v5), and when Ezra blesses God, they worship Yahweh with all enthusiasm. Often through the millennia have gatherings of God’s people engaged in heartfelt worship—humanity’s finest and fullest moments. With assistance from various individuals, Ezra makes sure that the Word of God is not only read, but understood (vv6-8). The believing mind is not to be unengaged or passive, but instructed in what is really healthy (Tit 2:1ff).⁷³

Something else, it turns out, needs to be understood as well: for as much as the reading of the Scriptures illustrates the people’s failure to follow in God’s ways, bringing tears to their eyes, the real heartbeat of God’s revelation to humankind is not judgment, but mercy; not an end, but a beginning; not sin, but grace; not sorrow, but joy (vv9-12). There are times for soberness and sorrow, rebuke and reproof—but the driving force of Christian gatherings ought to be one of celebration of God’s great gospel.

Scripture, when really heard, calls for application, and when on a second day of gathering the people realizes that it is in fact time to celebrate the Feast of Shelters,⁷⁴ they eagerly do so (v13ff). So eagerly, in fact, that not since Joshua had first led the people into this land had such a celebration been seen (v17). And as once Moses led his people in song at their deliverance from slavery to human oppression (Ex 15:1ff), so God’s people will one day again sing the song of Moses, celebrating their deliverance from slavery to unrighteousness in all its forms (Rev 15:2ff).

N 8:2 Children’s ministry has its place, but a church should not be too quick to deprive young people of the chance of hearing God’s word publicly (Betts, 130-131). The phrase “all who could listen with understanding” allows for the dismissal of those too young to understand or those with significant mental disabilities, together with their caretakers.

N 8:3 What exactly was read on this and the following days? Here it is called “the book of the law” (cf. Dt 29:21, 30:10, Josh 1:8, 8:31, v34, 23:6, 24:26, 2 Ki 14:6, 22:8, 11, 2 Chron 34:15), and in 9:3 it will be called “the book of the law of the LORD” (cf. 2 Chron 17:9, 34:14). There are arguments that can be made

⁷² On this chapter relative to the second chapter of Ezra, see Appendix 2.

⁷³ This quotation, though written some time ago, remains true: “The constituent nature of human beings did not change with Generation X, nor did it change with the Baby Boomers... [T]echnology changes the way we do things, but the fundamental nature of our humanity remains the same as when God created Adam and Eve. The way to the heart is through the mind, so mindless Christianity never really produces purification of the soul. The purification of the soul comes through obeying the truth of the Word of God through the Spirit of God” (Sproul, 36).

⁷⁴ See the comments on Ezra Chapter Three.

on various grounds that in a context like this the singular term “book” is meant in a general sense, so the whole Pentateuch were read (or representative selections from the whole Pentateuch: it is hard to be sure from the wording in this passage whether the entire book of the law was read, or only much of it). The overall impression given here is of a single scroll, while each book of the Bible was originally contained on individual scrolls).⁷⁵ Also, early in the reading the people react with great sorrow (v9), which seems more natural in response to the exhortative material that permeates Deuteronomy than to the extended narratives of Genesis. Then too, it is on the second day that they encounter the idea of the Feast of Shelters (v13ff), and it seems somewhat more likely that they would have encountered Dt 16:13ff on the second day of a slow reading of Deuteronomy (cf. also on v7 below) than that they would have encountered Lev 23:24ff on the second day of a reading and explanation of the whole Pentateuch. My proposal, then, is that Ezra read the entire book of Deuteronomy, perhaps supplemented with readings from or summaries of pertinent cross references from elsewhere in the Pentateuch, but certainly accompanied by extensive explanation (cf. v7ff).⁷⁶

N 8:4 Why are these men with Ezra on the platform? We are not told. Perhaps they were leaders, and in that capacity representing the will of the people to be around God’s Word. Perhaps they took turns with Ezra in the task of reading the book.⁷⁷

N 8:5 *all the people stood up*: This seems, like so much in this chapter, to be a spontaneous act. The practice in some modern churches of asking the congregation to stand for the reading of God’s Word has much to commend it (encouraging reverence for the words of Scripture, marking that moment off as different from the normal course of weekly events), but is not strictly necessary, any more than that on each such occasion the congregation should go on to put their faces on the ground (v6). Whatever the outward expression, the inward disposition should be one of attentive respect for God’s Word and overwhelmed awe at God’s blessedness.

N 8:6 *Amen* (אמן): This is a transliteration of the Hebrew. The term comes from a root connoting surety or faithfulness. Sometimes “amen” reflects consent to terms (Num 5:22, Dt 27:15) or a shared wish for something to transpire (Jer 28:6); more often, it reflects agreement with notions of God’s blessedness (Ps 106:48), as here.

N 8:7 Seven men different from the thirteen on the platform (cf. v4) took an active part in explaining. It is unclear whether this means that they added in their own words of paraphrase and explanation, or whether their job was to repeat the words being uttered on the platform, thus extending the message to people

⁷⁵ The Hebrew term ספר (here, “book” in the CSB) is a broad term for various kinds of written media, but generally a scroll is meant. Scrolls were at that time the usual form a lengthy work would take.

⁷⁶ Ezra (much more than Nehemiah) became a revered figure in intertestamental Judaism and beyond, particularly as regards his relationship to the transmission of Scripture. Many traditions about him, and several apocryphal books supposedly about or from him, developed in the late Second Temple period and beyond. A few of these ideas have left their stamp on mainstream Judaism, but for the most part these traditions had little staying power, and there is very little to them. Apart from those whose field is historical theology, Christians can safely leave these matters aside. Ezra was an important and godly leader, but his accomplishments should not be inflated.

⁷⁷ It should be noted that in addition to the challenge of projecting the voice in an open-air environment without modern audio equipment, there is the challenge of deciphering the text: at that time the Hebrew text would have been written without unambiguous vowel signs, without punctuation of any kind, without section headings or footnotes, with few (or possibly no) paragraph breaks, probably in quite a different script than most people were used to (the Scriptures being then, and for a considerable period thereafter, apparently written in the ancient Hebrew script, which differed radically from the Aramaic script that the people had probably by then adopted and retain to this day) and certainly written in a different kind of Hebrew than the readers were used to (a millennium having elapsed between Moses’ day and Ezra’s). A somewhat comparable experience could be gained by a modern reader being called upon to read from a facsimile of the Geneva Bible to a large congregation without a microphone.

beyond the earshot of Ezra.

N 8:8 *translating* (מפרש): The meaning of this Hebrew word here has long been the subject of debate. Were the men translating Deuteronomy (or whatever passage it was) from Hebrew into Aramaic, since the people, so recently returned from Mesopotamia, now spoke the regional lingua franca, Aramaic? Or were the men explaining Deuteronomy, since Hebrew had evolved over the years and could present difficulties even for native speakers, and since the words of Moses often pose vexing questions of interpretation? The second explanation seems to fit the evidence best (*pace* Koehler and Baumgartner, 2: 976b). The root פִּרַשׁ is used in reference to clarity, not translation, in Lev 24:12 and Num 15:34;⁷⁸ it also denotes explanation in Mishnaic Hebrew (Jastrow, 1242) and Qumran Aramaic (Cook, 195). Ezra 4:7 uses a different verb (תרגם) to describe translation (and that involving Aramaic). Linguistic analysis of the Bar Kochba fragments,⁷⁹ and Mishnaic Hebrew,⁸⁰ and other sources has amply demonstrated that Hebrew continued to evolve in ways not predictable from a putative recovery of the language via study of the Bible. The many names in the book of EN in some cases show evidence of contact with other languages, but for the most part display a solidly Hebrew foundation. Considering that there were some at the laying of the foundation of the second temple who could remember the first temple (E 3:12), it does not seem that command of the Hebrew language had been lost—at most it was weakened. True, the following phrase “and giving the meaning” (וְשׁוֹם שְׂכָל) might seem redundant on this account, but intentional repetition is a hallmark of orality in general (with few, if any, exceptions, the books of the Bible were originally written to be read out loud). It is also possible that a slight difference in nuance is present, the first term referring more to putting into place the building blocks of understanding, the second to the subsequent construction of a nuanced, practicable grasp of the content.

N 8:9 Granting that in Hebrew style it is fairly standard to switch between grammatical persons, Nehemiah is so consistent in referring to himself in the first person that the third person reference to him (plus the label “the governor”) probably indicates that in this chapter (and in the two following chapters) we have a document different than the Nehemiah Memoirs that the editor of EN has chosen to insert at this point.

N 8:14 “An indicator of true repentance is an immediate desire to obey God’s word” (Betts, 141).

Nehemiah Chapter Nine

In the same month as the events of the previous chapter, the people again gather, again awash in sadness (v1). They spend considerable time in Bible reading, confession, and worship (vv1-4). Then the Levites encourage the people to bless God (see the second note on v5 below regarding the translation): again, as on point the people is when they confess to being grievously sinful, there is no need to remain in a sorrowful headspace, when redemption is to be found in their God, the great and good king of the heavens. This then leads the levites to sing a song that traces God’s unmerited grace throughout Israel’s history—indeed, the passage can well be read as a summary of virtually the entire OT—in the end appealing to God to continue his liberating work in their own day (vv6-37). After blessing God and confessing their monotheism (vv5-6a), the levites summarize Genesis as God creating everything, choosing Abraham, and promising him the land (vv6b-8); summarize the rest of the Pentateuch as God delivering his people from Pharaoh, giving them the law at Sinai, and protecting them in the wilderness, despite their stubborn sin (vv9-23); summarize Joshua as God’s faithfulness in giving them the land (vv24-25); and summarize the rest of the historical narratives as the people devolving into a cycle of apostasy (vv26-32), while God remains both righteous and merciful. With the words “so now” (וְעַתָּה, often an important transitional marker in Hebrew), the Levites pivot to their appeal to God, begging for him to set them truly free

⁷⁸ The irony of quoting from the Pentateuch in this connection can hardly pass unnoticed.

⁷⁹ A famous example is the developments of firms of the type אֶת הַעֵיר לְעֵיר תֵּעִיר for אֶת הַעֵיר.

⁸⁰ See Segal, 48 and *passim*.

(vv32-37).

As in Ezra 10, the people decide to formalize their repentance by signing a vow (v38).

N 9:1 Based on the timestamps here and in 8:2, it has been twenty-three days since the law began to be read to the people. Despite the injunctions of 8:9ff, the people are still in a mournful state of mind (as seen in the cultural indications of mourning—avoiding food and wearing uncomfortable, dirty clothing). For modern-day Christians, too, the joy that comes from the gospel is something that people often need to be reminded of, more than once or twice.

N 9:2 *Those of Israelite descent separated themselves from all foreigners*: It is not clear whether this means that another mass divorce took place, or whether gentiles were excluded from the assembly. As discussed with regard to Ezra chapters eight and nine, there was great spiritual danger in intermarrying, yet also quite possibly an early form of pharisaism emerging here—extending the Mosaic law beyond what it was meant to enjoin, and stoking the fires of ethnocentrism.

N 9:3 Throughout history powerful movements of God have been associated with the grouping together of reverent reading of Scripture, open confession of sin, and passionate worship of God.

N 9:4 A rotation of men neither matching those on the platform before (8:4) nor those among the people (8:7) is on the platform this time. Perhaps those arranging Christian conferences should likewise have a variety of speakers, rather than the same lineup each time. Certainly an overreliance of the most famous communicators is problematic.

N 9:5 *Stand up*: Standing was often a mark of respect, and that respect for God might be the idea here. On the other hand, the Hebrew (קומו ברכו) is most naturally read as imparting intentionality or urgency.⁸¹ In English, a comparable effect might be with the addition of a direct address, plus an emotional pitch to the command: “O Israel, bless the Lord your God!”

N 9:5 *Blessed be the LORD your God* (ברכו את יהוה אלהיכם): As the Hebrew shows, this should be “Bless the LORD your God,” i.e. a command to declare the goodness of God. Furthermore, the prayer should be understood to begin at this point, not with “Blessed by your glorious name” (which in Hebrew starts with a conjunction: “And blessed,” etc.).⁸²

N 9:5 *and may it be exalted above all blessing and praise* (ומרומם על כל ברכה ותהלה): This seems to mean, “and may it [viz., your name] be recognized as more deserving of being blessed and praised than any competitor.”

N 9:6 *and all the stars of heaven worship you* (וצבא השמים לך משתהוים): It is not quite certain whether the CSB is right render צבא as “stars”—the meaning might be “angelic host” (the rendering “worship” would then be adjusted to “worships”).

N 9:8 *You have fulfilled your promise* (ותקם את דבריך): Lit., “You have established your words,” “establish” (קום in the *hiph’il* stem) being a key word for confirming a covenant. Sometimes theologians depict the land promises to Abraham as being utterly unfilled at any time in history to date (and therefore

⁸¹ Such seems to be general sense both when קום is used as a quasi-auxiliary, and when two imperative verbs are put together without a conjunction between them.

⁸² I am puzzled as to how this CSB rendering could have arisen. If the translators have not emended the text unaccounted (the cross references the translation provides are 2 Chr 16:36, Ps 41:13, 106), my only guess is that they are taking the subject of the verb as being believers of all ages, not the specific people in the Levites’ presence that day, and then paraphrased the eternal command to praise as a statement about God’s eternal praiseworthiness.

requiring a future, millennial ethnic polity to fulfil it), but the picture seems to be more nuanced than that. Israel did occupy and multiply in the promised land (1 Ki 4:20), yet Abraham himself looked beyond merely a piece of land of western Asia to a city with God as its builder (Heb 10:8ff). The present passage notes the faithfulness of God in keeping his word with the Hebrews as it relates to the promised land; it will go on (v32) to call on God to be faithful in keeping his word as it relates to the bondage of sin within them and sinful rulers over them.

N 9:13 *reliable instructions* (תורות אמת): Lit., “laws of truth,” perhaps a subtle undermining of Persian imperial ideology with its love of truth.⁸³

N 9:13 *guiding them on their journey* (להנחתם בהדרך): This is one indication among others that the scribes who copied Scripture did so reliably, for here they preserved, rather than corrected, a rare (dialectal?) form.

N 9:20 *You sent your good Spirit to instruct them*: The Holy Spirit did not permanently indwell each believer then as now, but he was particularly active the days of the exodus and wilderness wanderings to teach and guide the people (Isa 63:11; cf. Hag 2:5).

N 9:22 On these formidable kings defeated by God’s providence, see Num 21:21ff and Dt 3:1ff. These remarkable victories would be frequently referenced long thereafter (e.g., Ps 135:11, 136:20).

N 9:32 *from the days of the Assyrian kings until today*: Despite the fact that it was the Northern, not the Southern, Kingdom that the Assyrians deported (2 Ki 17:1ff), the levites start the clock of imperial oppression with the Assyrians, not with the later Babylonians. For them, neither the split of the kingdom into two (1 Ki 12:1ff) nor the deportation of the Northern Kingdom broke the essential continuity of God’s people, nor God’s faithfulness to it (cf. the comments on Ezra chapter eight above).

N 9:33 *we have acted wickedly*: “When we see sin, we are close to the light. Only when we *don’t* see our sin should we be suspicious of our hearts” (Welch, 61; he goes on to quote 1 Jn 1:8).

N 9:36-37 As often, here the African American community can sympathize with the Jews. Though present in the land they and the fathers before them have lived in, they have often been made to feel excluded from it, even at times asked to leave; and though slavery technically was ended in the mid-nineteenth century, it not be until the mid-twentieth century when civil rights were widely recognized, and as the middle of the twenty-first century approaches, much progress remains to be made.

N 9:38 *we*: Apparently the author of the document that constitutes N 8-10 (cf. on 8:9 above) was present for these events.

Nehemiah Chapter Ten

The editor of EN, true to his or her God-given personality as an archivist, records the signatories to the vow of 9:38 in 10:1-29, together with its contents (vv30-39). As always, we are reminded that God knows each and every person, every individual joy and sorrow. But as with Ezra 10, we might question whether the people are overstepping their bounds (v30; see on Ezra 10). Nor will the lofty ideals of the vow be fulfilled by this people, as time will tell.

Nehemiah Chapter Eleven

By a mix of lottery (v1) and volunteerism (v2), the city of Jerusalem is repopulated (cf. on chapter seven

⁸³ The deuterocanonical book of 1 Esdras contains an apocryphal story (whether original to 1 Esdras or added later is debated) of Zerubbabel exiling the power of truth.

above). This chapter provides the key names and some of the numbers involved (vv3-24). A supplement describes some of the surrounding areas (vv25-36). What Ulrich says (43) about the returnees of Ezra chapter two applies here as well: “History may forget most of them, but they do not escape God’s attention.” Nor will we who likewise follow in God’s ways, forsaking all else (Mat 19:29).

Nehemiah Chapter Twelve

In another supplement,⁸⁴ the first part of this chapter lists some of the priests of levites (vv1-26).

Another of the joyous high points of the book gets under way: the walls are dedicated (cf. on chapter three) with great fanfare (vv27ff). As with the dedication of the temple (E 3:13), the rejoicing is “hear far away” (v27). The people spares no expense in caring for the priests and levites (v44), and the historical precedents of David and Asaph are followed with regard to the musical aspect of worship (vv45-46).⁸⁵ “Those who lived in Ezra-Nehemiah’s Jerusalem might have sampled a preview of the city of God (the ‘now’), but fell short [as we will see] of the eventual perfection of the inhabitants of the New Jerusalem (the ‘not yet’)” (Ulrich, 160).

N 12:23 *the Book of Historical Events* (ספר דברי הימים): This is “the archival document in the temple, and not to be confused with the biblical books of the same name [1 and 2 Chronicles, which in Hebrew have the same name]. In archival material the registration was only taken up to the time of Johanan the high priest (c. 400 BC). In v. 22 the author indicates that he has material at his disposal which takes the registration up to the time of Jaddua (well after Johanan), but this later material is not as yet copied in archival documents of the temple” (Fensham, 253).

N 12:23 *son of* (בן): Descendant of, as often with this Hebrew word.

N 12:45-57 A passage such as this creates a certain degree of precedent for a denominational directory of worship, but such should be done with care and circumspection, given the ease with which such things can in practice crowd out the sufficiency of Scripture and replace the commands of God with the traditions of people.⁸⁶

Nehemiah Chapter Thirteen

In another public reading of the law (a tradition begun in chapter eight), the issue of intermarriage again comes up (see Ezra chapter nine), and is handled as before: a mass divorce (vv1-3). This discouraging situation comes in a context of a different travesty: while Nehemiah was away, in service to the emperor (vv6-7a), Eliashib, though a priest, had allowed his brother Tobiah to move into the temple grounds (vv4-5). This unlawful intrusion into a holy place had both profaned the temple (v9) and left the legitimate servants of the temple lacking what they needed to do their job properly and securely (v10). Nehemiah throws out Tobiah and his possessions (v8), and rebukes all involved (v11) before setting things back in order (vv12-13). As so often, he can only appeal to God for proper recognition of his labors under tremendous strain (v14).

The troubles continue: Nehemiah discovers that the Sabbath day is being profaned by businessmen (vv14-16). He again has to rebuke the people (vv17-18), and take stern measures to put a stop to the business (vv19-22a)—as Jesus would later on (Mat 21:12f). He keeps his eyes heavenward (v22b), from which place alone his reward can come (Isa 40:10).

⁸⁴ It will be recalled that the original text did not have chapter breaks.

⁸⁵ See the Overview of the Book section of the Introduction.

⁸⁶ When a business, non-profit organization, or social club has been around for a while, its culture inevitably will have changed somewhat over time. At times deliberately and at times unconsciously, it has added written or unwritten rules to its hiring process, the ways and timing in which people are allowed to ask questions or raise concerns, the personality types it elevates for promotion, etc. The church has not been fundamentally different, and it is part of the task of the Church again and again to cut back on accretions and return to the teachings of Scripture.

The troubles just keep coming: Nehemiah learns that some men have married women from foreign-run cities (v23), and many had not even gone to the trouble of teaching their children Hebrew (v24), so little did their heritage as God's people mean to them. The pattern is clear by now: rebukes follow (vv25-27), along with setting things straight (vv28, 30-31a) and appeals to God (vv29, 31b).

"The conclusion of the book of Nehemiah is sobering... it ends with a picture of enemies who appeared to be defeated earlier in the book rising up and continuing to cause trouble for Nehemiah and the people of God. It is the picture of a people who demonstrated wonderful commitment to the Lord who [later] abandon these commitments and apparently forsake their God. The law can never save them from their sin; it was never intended to save... The Lord Jesus did for us what we could not do for ourselves. He was born of a virgin, he lived a sinless life, he offered himself as our substitute on the cross, and he died for our sin" (Betts, 217).⁸⁷

N 13:1 *no Moabite or Ammonite should ever enter the assembly of God*: Dt 23:4; see on E 9:1-2 for discussion.

N 13:4 *Tobiah*: Was this the same man as before? He is not identified, but perhaps he was a relative with the same name. He seems in any case to have been a cynical and self-serving man, the type for whom places of worship are soft targets. Churches must always be on their guard against such people.

N 13:24 *the language of Ashdod*: Some have thought that this language was a fusion (no longer in existence) of Hebrew, Aramaic, and Phoenician found all along the coast, but the evidence does not seem to bear this out (Mor). What language(s) the Philistines in general spoke is hard to pin down (Davis), and such might in any case have been replaced in this period by some other language, such as Aramaic or Phoenician (though if it was the former, Nehemiah probably would have referred to it by that term). In any case, the point is that some of the children in question were so disconnected from God's people as not even to be able to converse with them.⁸⁸

N 13:29 *the covenant of the priesthood and the Levites* (ברית הכהנה והלויים): Hutchinson (89-90) suggests that this is "a hybrid of Numbers 25:13... and Jer 33:21... This is an... argument in favor of the idea that the covenant made with Phineas comes to be integrated with the Levitical covenant."

Appendix 1: Themes in Ezra-Nehemiah

Themes are significant ideas, or idea-laden actions or images, that occur repeatedly and/or at critical junctures in a literary work.

MacArthur's comments on Ezra (vii) and Nehemiah (ix-x) combined capture some of the key themes of EN: (1) God's work continues, both despite and through pagan governance; (2) God's people face persistent—but ultimately unsuccessful—opposition in their work; and (3) God's Word is central to this ongoing work.⁸⁹

⁸⁷ See further Ulrich, 150ff.

⁸⁸ It is to some extent illustrative of the differences between how God's grace operated in OT times and how it operates in NT times that then people interested in the one true God had to learn the language(s) of God's people, but at Pentecost God's people proclaimed the gospel in the languages of those in need of it (Ac 2:5ff).

⁸⁹ Larson and Dahlen (121-122) make some helpful comments in this connection (concerning Ezra, but relevant for Nehemiah as well): "The Book of Ezra narrates the spiritual development and reorganization of the postexilic Jews... But the people had to resolve their questions without the aid of a miraculous twist of nature, or a thunderous voice from the mountain, or a fire to illuminate their way. Instead, the people were left with a book. So they read of distant time and of people who, even to them, were known as ancients... Ezra, however, believed firmly in the adequacy of God's revelation. Consequently, he practiced scriptural interpretation. From the stories extracted principles that reached across the years and epochs; he looked to historical specifics to discover ageless, universal doctrines. Then he returned to the particular, applying what he understood to daily life. The practice has continued through the centuries to this day. It requires caution and prayer and the counsel of the complete Scriptures in light of

One of the subthemes, seen at several major junctures, is that of joy (E 3:12f, 6:16ff, N 8:10, 12:43). The setting of joy in EN is instructive, for (at least in the global West) joy tends to be individualized, but here it is seen as a function of God's people collectively obeying and worshiping him.

Another subtheme is leadership, for several men—most notably, Zerubbabel and Jeshua, Haggai and Zechariah, and Ezra and Nehemiah—spur the people on to action and to some extent guide them politically and spiritually. But as valid and important as recognition of this subtheme is, it requires some qualification. Using EN (and the book of Nehemiah in particular) as a sort of guidebook for successful leadership (1) tends to involve hasty generalizations from particular circumstances in a long-ago time to different, later situations; (2) tends to assume that somehow following certain principles will guarantee financial success, when Jesus pronounced his blessing on the poor (Lk 6:20), not the rich; and (3) tends to overlook and overshadow the actual burdens of the author, as sketched above, and the place of the book in the progressing narrative of the Bible as a whole (for some discussion of which, see Appendix 7 below).

Appendix 2: The Differences between Ezra 2 and Nehemiah 7

The list in Ezra chapter two reappears—though with quite a few differences—in Nehemiah chapter seven 7, prompting two questions: (1) why the repetition, and (2) why the variation?

As to the first question, Nehemiah states (7:5) that while preparing to conduct a census he found a document listing those he returned. This document he incorporated into his own memoirs. One follow-up question here is whether the document Nehemiah found was Ezra's memoir. Nehemiah's description of what he found does not give this impression (so also Steinmann, 165-166), and it is not clear to me that 2:1ff is actually part of Ezra's memoir (which might not start until 7:1). I suspect that the author/editor of the unnamed document⁹⁰ that constitutes (all or parts of) the first six chapters of EN had seen and incorporated the same document. In any case, the fact that the document is reproduced as it stands, rather than summarized by the editor of EN, attests to the list's vital importance.

As to the second question, the original text of both chapters of EN (viz., E 2 and N 7) must be determined by judicious examination application of the principles of textual criticism. For convenience, my best attempt to reconstruct the text appears side by side in translation below, with some brief commentary and conclusion following.⁹¹

Ezra 2	Nehemiah 7
<i>And these are the sons of the province, those who came up from the captivity of the exile which Nebuchadnezzar, emperor of Babylon, had taken to captivity in Babylon: they returned to Jerusalem and Judea, each man to his city. 2 Those who entered [the land of Israel] with Zerubbabel, Jesus, Nehemiah, Seraiah, Reelaiah, Naamani, Mordecai, Bilshan, Mesapper, Bigvai, Rehum, and Baanah—the number of the men of the people of Israel [is as follows]:</i> 3 <i>The sons of Parosh, 2,172.</i> 4 <i>The sons of Shephatiah, 372.</i> 5 <i>The sons of Arah, 775.</i> 6 <i>The sons of Pahath-moab (that is, the</i>	<i>These are the sons of the province, those who came up from the captivity of the exile which Nebuchadnezzar, emperor of Babylon, had taken to captivity: they returned to Jerusalem and Judea, each man to his city. 7 The people returning [to the land of Israel] with Zerubbabel, Jesus, Nehemiah, Seraiah, Raamiah, Naamani, Mordecai, Bilshan, Mesappereth, Bigvai, Rehum, and Baanah—the number of the men of the people of Israel [were the following]:</i> 8 <i>The sons of Parosh, 2,172.</i> 9 <i>The sons of Shephatiah, 372.</i> 10 <i>The sons of Arah, 652.</i> 11 <i>The sons of Pahath-moab (that is, the</i>

the context. But through divine wisdom we, too, must dig beneath the details of biblical texts and expose the eternal so that, like Ezra, we can bring it back to earth through practical use."

⁹⁰ Written perhaps by Zerubbabel, but this is little more than a guess on my part.

⁹¹ The Hebrew text is that of the Solid Rock Hebrew Bible (<https://github.com/jjmccollum/solid-rock-hb>).

sons of Jesus [and] Joab), 2,812.

7 The sons of Elam, 1,254.

8 The sons of Zattu, 945.

9 The sons of Zaccai, 760.

10 The sons of Bani, 648.

11 The sons of Bebai, 623.

12 The sons of Azgad, 1,222.

13 The sons of Adonikam, 667.

14 The sons of Bigvai, 2,056.

15 The sons of Adin, 454.

16 The sons of Ater of Hezekiah), 98.

17 The sons of Bezai, 323.

18 The sons of Hariph, 112.

19 The sons of Hashum, 223.

20 The sons of Gibbar, 95.

21 The men of Bethlehem, 123.

22 The men of Netophah, 55.

23 The men of Anathoth, 128.

24 The sons of Azmaveth, 42.

25 The sons of Kiriath-jearim, Cephirah, and Beeroth, 743.

26 The sons of Ramah and Geba, 621.

27 The sons of Michmash, 122.

28 The sons of Bethel and Ai, 223.

29 The sons of Nebo, 52.

30 The sons of Magbish, 156.

31 The sons of the other Elam, 1,254.

32 The sons of Hiram, 320.

33 The sons of Lod, Hadid, and Ono, 725.

34 The sons of Jericho, 345.

35 The sons of Senaah, 3,630.

36 The priests:

The sons of Jedaiah, to the house of Jesus, 973.

37 The sons of Immer, 1,052.

38 The sons of Pashhur, 1,247.

39 The sons of Harim, 1,017.

40 The levites:

The sons of Jesus and Kadmiel to the sons of Hodaviah, 74.

41 The singers:

The sons of Asaph, 148.

42 The sons of the gatekeepers:

The sons of Shallum, the sons of Ater, the sons of Talmon, the sons of Akkub, the sons of Hatita, [and] the sons of Shobai—the total, 139.

43 The acolytes:

The sons of Ziha, the sons of Hasupha, the sons of Tabbaoth, **44** the sons of Keros, the sons of Siaha, the sons of Padon, **45** the sons of Lebanah,

sons of Jesus and Joab), 2,818.

12 The sons of Elam, 1,254.

13 The sons of Zattu, 845.

14 The sons of Zaccai, 760.

15 The sons of Binnui, 648.

16 The sons of Bebai, 628.

17 The sons of Azgad, 1,322.

18 The sons of Adonikam, 667.

19 The sons of Bigvai, 2,067.

20 The sons of Adin, 654.

21 The sons of Ater of Hezekiah, 98.

22 The sons of Hashum, 328.

23 The sons of Bezai, 324.

24 The sons of Hariph, 112.

25 The sons of Gibeon, 95.

26 The men of Bethlehem and Netophah, 188.

27 The men of Anathoth, 128.

28 The men of Beth-azmaveth, 42.

29 The sons of Kiriath-jearim, Cephirah, and Beeroth, 743.

30 The sons of Ramah and Geba, 621.

31 The sons of Michmash, 122.

32 The sons of Bethel and Ai, 123.

33 The sons of Nebo, 52.

34 The sons of the other Elam, 1,254.

35 The sons of Hiram, 320.

36 The sons of Jericho, 345.

37 The sons of Lod, Hadid, and Ono, 721.

38 The sons of Senaah, 3,930.

39 The priests:

The sons of Jedaiah, to the house of Jesus, 973.

40 The sons of Immer, 1,052.

41 The sons of Pashhur, 1,247.

42 The sons of Harim, 1,017.

43 The levites

The sons of Jesus [and] of Kadmiel, of the sons of Hodaviah, 74.

44 The singers:

The sons of Asaph, 148.

45 The sons of the gatekeepers, the sons of Shallum, the sons of Ater, the sons of Talmon, the sons of Akkub, the sons of Hatita, [and] the sons of Shobai—the total, 138.

46 The acolytes [are as follows]: the sons of Ziha, the sons of Hasupha, the sons of Tabbaoth, **47** the sons of Keros, the sons of Sia, the sons of Padon, **48** the sons of Lebanah, the sons of Hagabah, the sons of Shalmal, **49** the sons

the sons of Hagabah, the sons of Akkub, **46** the sons of Hagab, the sons of Shalmal, the sons of Hanan, **47** the sons of Giddel, the sons of Gahar, the sons of Reaiah, **48** the sons of Rezin, the sons of Nekoda, the sons of Gazzam, **49** the sons of Uzza, the sons of Paseah, the sons of Besai, **50** the sons of Asnah, the sons of Meunim, the sons of Nephisim, **51** the sons of Bakbuk, the sons of Hakupha, the sons of Harhur, **52** the sons of Bazluth, the sons of Mehida, the sons of Harsha, **53** the sons of Barkos, the sons of Sisera, the sons of Temah, **54** the sons of Nezia, [and] the sons of Hatipha, **55** The sons of Solomon's servants [are as follows]: The sons of Sotai, the sons of Hassophereth, the sons of Perida, **56** the sons of Jaalah, the sons of Darkon, the sons of Giddel, **57** the sons of Shephatiah, the sons of Hattil, the sons of Pochereth-hazzebaim, and the sons of Ummi**58**—the total of the acolytes and of the sons of Solomon's servants, 392.

59 And these are they who went up from Tel-melah, Tel-harsha, Cherub, Addan, [and] Immer; but they were not able to show their fathers' house or their seed, as to whether they were from Israel: **60** the sons of Delaiah, the sons of Tobiah, [and] the sons of Nekoda, 652.

61 And from the priests: the sons of Habaiah, the sons of Hakkoz, [and] the sons of the Barzillai (he who had taken a wife from the daughters of Barzillai the Gileadite, and was called by their name)—**62** these men who were aiming to be enrolled in the genealogical records sought their documentation, but they were not found, and were ruled ineligible for the priesthood. **63** And the governor said to them that they were not to eat from the most holy things until there should arise a priest with the Urim and Thumim.

64 The whole congregation together was 42,360, **65** beside their male servants and their female servants (these were 7,337), and they had 245 male singers and female singers. **66** Their horses were 736, their mules were 245, **67** their camels were 435, [and] their donkeys were 6,720.

68 And from the family leaders, when they went to the house of Yahweh which is in Jerusalem, made freewill offerings for the house of God to cause it to stand in its place: **69** according to their ability they gave to the fund for the project, [the total being] 61,000 gold darics,

of Hanan, the sons of Giddel, the sons of Gahar, **50** the sons of Reaiah, the sons of Rezin, the sons of Nekoda, **51** the sons of Gazzam, the sons of Uzza, the sons of Paseah, **52** the sons of Besai, the sons of Meunim, the sons of Nephisim, **53** the sons of Bakbuk, the sons of Hakupha, the sons of Harhur, **54** the sons of Bazluth, the sons of Mehida, the sons of Harsha, **55** the sons of Barkos, the sons of Sisera, the sons of Temah, **56** the sons of Nezia, [and] the sons of Hatipha, **57** The sons of Solomon's servants [are as follows]: The sons of Sotai, the sons of Hassophereth, the sons of Perida, **58** the sons of Jaalah, the sons of Darkon, the sons of Giddel, **59** the sons of Shephatiah, the sons of Hattil, the sons of Pochereth-hazzebaim, and the sons of Ummi**60**—the total of the acolytes and of the sons of Solomon's servants, 392.

61 And these are they who went up from Tel-melah, Tel-harsha, Cherub, Addon, and Immer; but they were not able to show their fathers' house or their seed, as to whether they were from Israel: **62** the sons of Delaiah, the sons of Tobiah, [and] the sons of Nekoda, 642.

63 And from the priests: the sons of Habaiah, the sons of Hakkoz, [and] the sons of the Barzillai (he who had taken a wife from the daughters of Barzillai the Gileadite, and was called by their name)—**64** these men who were aiming to be enrolled in the genealogical records sought their documentation, but they were not found, and were ruled ineligible for the priesthood. **65** And the governor said to them that they were not to eat from the most holy things until there should arise a priest with the Urim and Thumim.

64 The whole congregation together was 42,360, **67** beside their male servants and their female servants (these were 7,337), and they had 245 male singers and female singers. **68** The horses were 736, the mules were 245, the camels were 435, [and] the donkeys were 6,720. **69** And some of the family leaders gave to the project; the governor gave to the treasury 1,000 gold darics, 50 bowls, [and] 350 changes of priestly clothes.

70 And from the family leaders, they gave to the fund for the project, [the total being] 20,000 gold darics, 2,200 silver minas; **71** and that which the rest of the people gave: 20,000 gold darics, and 2,000 minas, and 67 changes of priestly

5,000 silver minas, and 100 changes of priestly clothes.

70 And the priests and levites—as well as, from among the [lay] people, the singers, gatekeepers and acolytes—dwelled in their cities, and all Israel [dwelled] in their cities.

clothes.

72 And the priests and the Levites and the gatekeepers and the singers—as well as, from among the [lay] people, acolytes—dwelled in their cities, and all Israel [dwelled] in their cities.

E 2:2 The fourth name is שריה here in M-E 2:2 but עזריה in M-N 7:7. The versions support these two different names in these two places, except that 1 Es 5:8 has Ζαπαου in its representation of E 2:2. That Greek form *could* be an unusual transcription of שריה (one would expect an initial *sigma* rather than a *zeta*), but it could also represent עזריה, because of inner-greek corruption (a constant problem with Semitic proper names), because, owing to a weakening of the guttural letters in some dialects of Hebrew and Aramaic, the initial syllable of that name was not sounded in the dialect of the translator, or because of some other reason that is obscure to me. The equation of עזריה and Ζαπαου occurs with virtual certainty in 1 Es 8:2 (=E 7:1). Some suggest (e.g., Steinmann, 154) that 1 Esdras is copying from Nehemiah, but, while this possibility must be borne in mind, there are numerous cases where the author of 1 Esdras *could* have conformed Ezra's list to Nehemiah's, but seemingly did not bother to do so. The two Hebrew names are visually similar: one could plausibly hypothesize a textual corruption, wherein either *sin* became *ayin* and a corrupt dittograph of *resh* caused a superfluous *zayin* to appear, or wherein *ayin* became *sin* and *zayin* was overlooked in front of the similar-looking *resh* that follows. Both names are highly plausible, as both are attested in post-exilic times. In fact, the two names occur in close proximity in E 7:1 and in N 10:2, which proximity might have contributed to the error here. Impressed by the visual similarity of the two names and the fact that there is a possible transcriptional trigger in addition to the visual element (viz., two passages in the same book where these names are near one another), I suggest that one of these names is in error. Intrinsic evidence in favor of one name over the other is hard to come by, but the fact that documentary evidence seems probably to exist for reading עזריה in E 2:2 leads me to favor that reading.

E 2:2 Naamani: This name, evidently an alternative form of “Nehemiah,” dropped by accident from the M family of MSS.

E 2:6 Jesus [and] Joab: Whether to read ישוע יואב with M-E 2:2 (plus most versions) or ישוע ויואב with 1 Esdras 5:11 is a difficult one. The parallel passage (N 7:11) seemingly has the conjunction, which might have been lost in the midst of the large number of more or less vertical shafts in the near vicinity (viz., the *ayin* and *waw* with which ישוע ends and the *yodh* and *waw* of the following name). On the other hand, asyndeton would seem to be the kind of difficulty that the author of 1 Esdras would have smoothed over. (The relevant αα in 1 Esdras is missing in MS 108, but this MS seems to transfer readings between 1 and 2 Esdras rather freely.) The Nehemiah passage is a bit problematic as well, in that some important witnesses (notably B S L) omit the conjunction there; and if such is the original text of the OG, perhaps N 7:11 is to be read as יואב rather than ויואב as in M (an unconscious emendation, perhaps?). That said, it would not be too surprising for the Greek witnesses B S to omit a small word like αα (though admittedly the present case is a strange one), and the L group is, as likely as not, assimilating to E 2:6. Asyndeton in lists of names is rather distinctive of EN (cf. E 2:42, 54, 59, 61, 67), and is a feature of Hebrew lists (Young, 1:32n12). Then too, such a stylistic nicety might or might not be copied over in the other version of the list (viz., N 7:11). In the end, I retain M both in E 2:6 and in N 7:11, though hesitating both over the absence of the conjunction in the former and over the absence of it in the latter.

E 2:10 648: Where M reads ושנים, this is probably an error for ושמנה as in 1 Esdras 5:12 (cf. N 7:15). The form ושנים occurs rather more frequently in the near context than ושמנה, and this circumstance, together with the visual similarity of the two forms, led to the mistake.

E 2:13 Reading ושבעה for וששה with 1 Esdras 5:14, the latter being an assimilation to the other six-like numbers in this verse and/or to the end of v14.

E 2:18 The personal name חריף has been scrambled into יורה in M (following 1 Esdras 5:16; the Greek MSS seem to have suffered at this point, but such is not uncommon for Semitic names). For a similar sort of scrambling in which the word seems to have been perceived at some level as being in two halves, cf. the variation ספון ויתא for ויתאספון in Deut 33:21.

E 2:22 55: Reading וחמשה for וששה with 1 Esdras 5:18. The error in M is difficult to explain, but surely the other reading as the ring of truth, for in N 7:26 “the men of Bethlehem and Netophah” is given as 188,” and the numbers for those two places work out as 123+55=178; 1 Esdras 5:18 is not emending the text at this point, or otherwise it would have corrected the number further. So (as in N 7:20), we still lack documentation for the correct numbers, but can nevertheless get closer to the truth than we could if we insisted on reading only M.

E 2:25 The place name קרית יערם has suffered metathesis, facilitated by the unusual spelling.

E 2:41 148: I take עשרים in M to be a visual (and auditory?) error for ארבעים (following 1 Esdras 5:27; cf. N 7:44).

E 2:46 Shalmi: Just possibly, since the position of a liquid consonant is in question, this is linguistic metathesis, but given the form in N 7:48 and the external support for the same form here, it is most likely than textual metathesis is at work in M.

E 2:55 Perida: Following 1 Esdras 5:33 (and cf. N 7:57).

E 2:57 Um̄mi (אמי): Revocalizing M, I understand this name to derive from a Hebrew word for “people,” and comparable to such names as עמינדב. Cf. also the comments on N 7:59 below.

E 2:61 And from: Following 1 Esdras (cf. N 7:63), I read ומן, taking ומבני to be an assimilation to the extremely high frequency of the term בני in this passage, an assimilation facilitated by the visual similarity of these two forms.

E 2:65 245: Cf. 1 Es 5:41 and the parallel passage.

N 7:20 654: Reading וארבעה for וחמשה, the latter form being an assimilation to the preceding number. Admittedly, the overall number still does not match the parallel (Ez 2:25), but at least a tiny step has been made in the right direction.

N 7:54 Bazluth: The form בזלית is surely a *waw/yodh* error for בזלות (as in Ez 2:52).

N 7:59 Um̄mi: I take the OG Ημ̄μ to be a somewhat corrupt representation of אמי, the form found in E 2:57. This rare and puzzling form (on which see E 2:57) was in M at this point confused with the form אמון, a confusion helped along by the visual similarity of both *waw* and *nun* to *yodh*.

N 7:68 In M, the first two clauses dropped out by oversight. (Concerning the retroversion, note that the omission in Greek translation of the conjunction before the last component of the number is not unusual in 2 Esdras.)

It will be seen that in some cases the differences are illusory, one passage or the other having suffered in

transmission. But differences remain. An approach to textual criticism using conjectural emendations (viz., making inferences as to the original text that go beyond surviving documentation) would likely eliminate some of these remaining discrepancies—yet perhaps not all of them, since in some cases we are completely at a loss as to which form is correct, or whether a common error has spread to both. In cases like this, we must remain humble regarding the extent of our knowledge. On the other hand, we should not confuse uncertainty about various details with uncertainty about the message of the passage as a whole.

Appendix 3: Davidic Kingship in Ezra-Nehemiah

Levering does well to see a davidic (that is, messianic and royal) undertone to EN without rushing to import ideas from elsewhere in Scripture into the text. He musters three main arguments. (1) “First, as we have already seen, the prophets Haggai Zechariah play a significant role in the narrative of the book of Ezra and in the rebuilding of the temple. These prophets have a profound interest in the Davidic kingship” (121). (2) Second, the enemies’ repeated accusations concerning a coming Jewish kingship (among the passages Levering [122-123] cites are E 4:19 and N 6:5-7) have more than a kernel of truth to them: the “‘mighty kings’ [E 4:20; also 5:11] form the backdrop to the book of Ezra; they are by no means forgotten,” (122). (3) Ezra the Scribe [in E 9:34-37]... leads the people in renewing their covenantal obligations, clearly with the hope of a restoration that includes a Davidic king ruling in Jerusalem” (123).⁹²

But for all this, kingship is for the author of EN something in the background, not the foreground. Zerubbabel is an interesting case study in this regard. As a son of Shealtiel (E 3:2), who was a descendant of David (1 Chron 3:17), Zerubbabel might have made a claim to kingship. Yet the Persians evidently do not fear to send him with the others to Jerusalem; and when opponents of the Jews level charges of intent to become king, they dilate on Nehemiah (N 6:6). Zerubbabel’s repeated mention in EN and in Haggai and Zechariah indicates he exercised leadership at some level, even if only titular.⁹³ Perhaps there was a deliberate policy to keep a low profile in order to avoid provoking imperial suspicion; or perhaps Zerubbabel was fearful; or perhaps there was a feeling that if someday davidic kingship would be restored, that time had not come.⁹⁴ Whatever Zerubbabel felt about himself and his family line, he received assurances from God of his eternal significance (Hag 2:20-23, Zech 4:6-10) and lives on in the royal lineage of our Lord (Mat 1:11-12), a descendant of David according to the flesh (Rom 1:3).⁹⁵

Appendix 4: Ezra 4-6: Sequence and Composition

There are two principal difficulties in these three chapters. (1) Does 4:7-8 refer to one letter or to two letters? After all, v7 seems to be leading up to a letter that either never arrives, or one which seems in v8 suddenly to have different authorship. (2) How are the leaps in time to be understood? For Artaxerxes is written to in v7ff, but Darius shows up in v24ff.⁹⁶

⁹² To this it might be added that at some point—precisely when we do not know—an air of rebellion did begin to permeate Judea, such that, after the events of EN, Artaxerxes III would have to put down a rebellion there (Boardman, 146).

⁹³ Steinmann (33ff) makes a good case that Sheshbazzar was the first leader of the returning exiles, Zerubbabel following on Sheshbazzar’s death or retirement. But certainly Zerubbabel was one of the key leaders.

⁹⁴ When the Maccabees later regained sovereignty for the nation, there was no restoration of a davidic dynasty. Nor has the modern State of Israel showed any interest in this whatsoever.

⁹⁵ See further Harrington (173-175); for a still wider-ranging discussion on kingship, see Hamilton (227-241).

⁹⁶ For convenience, here is the basic sequence of Persian kings (see further the Introduction):

1. Cyrus
2. Cambyses
3. Darius I
4. Ahasuerus (=Xerxes)
5. Artaxerxes I
6. Darius II

Steinmann thinks that “Ezra 4:7 should be understood as the heading for the entire Aramaic documents (Ezra 4:8-6:18) that details the official Persian correspondence about building projects in Jerusalem, starting with the most recent (the building of the wall) and going back to the oldest (the building of the temple), with intervening narrative supplied by the authors of the report to link the individual pieces of the narrative” (234). On this account, 4:8 is not the same letter as that referred to in v7, but is the first of a bundle of letters and narrative kicked off by v7. In my view, the main strength of this approach is that it provides an explanation for why specifically 4:8-6:18 is in Aramaic (viz., because an Aramaic-language document is being imported directly into the framework of EN).⁹⁷ It is also the case that EN is certainly a fusional work, combining (at least) memoirs of Ezra and memoirs of Nehemiah, each of which embeds other material as well (particularly the lists of E 2 and N 7). The main weaknesses of Steinmann’s approach are that the content of 4:8-6:18 does not read like a letter to or from a Persian monarch (though it contains both within it); and, while this is open to debate, the narrative descriptions within it do not sound like they give an internal, Persian perspective on the events in this far-off province. Also, Steinmann has to render 4:24⁹⁸ in what to my mind is quite a strained way: “As a result the work stopped on the house of God in Jerusalem. In addition, it had [previously] remained stopped until the second year of the reign of King Darius of Persia” (237; brackets his).

Kidner suggests that v7 “is most probably self-contained, simply mentioning the sending of a letter but giving no details of it” (57). He finds that 4:6-23 is a digression, the main thread resuming at v24. Certainly, v6 mentions a letter without giving details, so that might be the case here as well. Kidner’s approach seems less complicated, and v24 in particular can be read straightforwardly as soon as it is recognized as picking up the thread from v5.⁹⁹ But the rationale for 4:8-6:18 being in Aramaic is left opaque. Also, the words at the end of v7 seem most naturally to be understood as introducing the content of an Aramaic letter, viz. v8ff.

As for the number of letters sent in E 4:7-8, it seems that Steinmann is right to see them as one letter, but with the modification that the people mentioned in v7 are the political instigators, while the people mentioned in v8 are the scribal enablers. As for the question of timing, Kidner’s overall approach seems more likely to me. My own suggestion for the reason for the shift to Aramaic is that 4:8, like Dan 2:4,¹⁰⁰ sees the first extended dialogue from characters in the narrative opposed to God; when, as in Dan 8:1, attention shifts away from gentile thrones to the interrelationship of God and his people, the language pivots back to Hebrew. Of course, E 7:12-26 is something of an anomaly here. Either—to be a bit eclectic in my theorizing—it is simply a verbatim quotation from an Aramaic source, or it is in Aramaic because it concerns gentile rule.

Appendix 5: Why is the Temple Rebuilt?

Few people in OT times would have asked this question, for to most of them the need for a temple would be self-evident.¹⁰¹ Indeed, without pressing this point, it can be suggested that one of the few voices to

7. Artaxerxes II

8. Artaxerxes III

9. Arsaces

10. Darius III

⁹⁷ A similar explanation can be given for why E 7:12-26 is likewise in Aramaic.

⁹⁸ The Aramaic runs thus: באדין בטלת עבדת בית אלהא די בירושלם והות בטלא עד שנת תרתין למלכות דריש מלך פרס

⁹⁹ Kidner (54) calls for the use of section headings to clarify matters. The CSB does this to some extent, though I’m not sure how clear it really makes things for the average reader. The NLT, with its penchant for slight (and usually helpful) paraphrase, makes things much clearer in its renderings of E 4:6 and v7; it renders v24 in a manner similar to CSB, but arguably helps clarify things with a footnote.

¹⁰⁰ That there is a related literary strategy in both Ezra-Nehemiah and Daniel is suggested by the similar announcement in both that Aramaic content will follow.

¹⁰¹ Reflecting on the temple as envisioned by the author of 1-2 Chronicles, Allen (240) writes, “In the temple era, so prized by the Chronicler, the temple became a monument to the grace of God as the channel of prayer and pardon. Moreover, as a place of sacrificial praise, it was a monument to the greatness of God. In both roles it witnessed to

broach the subject of a holiness that transcends ancient expectations (that of Ezekiel) finds it best to do so in temple language (chapters 40-48 of that book).

But from the vantage point of the present era, the situation is different: Christ offered himself up to God once for all (Heb 7:27, etc.) in the true, heavenly temple (9:11), making the Mosaic law obsolete (8:13). This would be accomplished when Jesus, the promised messiah, was born to Mary in Judea a few centuries after Ezra and Nehemiah walked the streets of Jerusalem. And in the promised New Jerusalem, there will be no temple (Rev 21:22; see Ulrich, 160f). Yet despite knowing (and planning) this epochal turn of events, God directs his returning people to rebuild the temple (Hag 1:4). Why?

I think that a few reasons can be inferred. (1) As mentioned above, from the vantage point of Ezra and his contemporaries, it would have been self-evident—at least at some level—that the worship of God must have a locus, and more specifically one consistent with the stipulations of the law of Moses. The day might be coming (though few, if any, truly understood this at the time) when a physical place would no longer be necessary,¹⁰² but that day had not yet arrived, and so full obedience to God demanded a rebuilt temple—hence the exhortations of Haggai and Zechariah, prophets of God.¹⁰³ (2) The successful rebuilding of the temple despite strident opposition was an indication that God’s plans for his people had not come to an end. A certain offspring (according to the flesh) of Abraham was yet to arrive.¹⁰⁴ (3) The existence of a functioning temple in Judea was necessary for Jesus Christ fully to experience and to encapsulate in himself the life of Israel, and also for him to fulfill certain prophecies (“zeal for your house has consumed me”). Relatedly, the existence of the temple in the days of Jesus’ ministry provided a foil for his own transcendent and eternal work.¹⁰⁵

Appendix 6: Views on the Mass Divorce

McConville sums up the conundrum of Ezra chapters 9 and 10 well: “Many readers of Ezra have taken offense at what they consider the harshness of enforcing mass divorce, with all the consequent misery for the rejected women and children. The measure is the more astonishing because it is impossible to plead that divorce is regarded as a natural or easily justifiable thing in the Old Testament. True, Old Testament law reckons with it (Deut. 24:1-4); yet this is not done in such a way as to approve it. And the prophet Malachi, possibly ministering close in time to Ezra, shows the Lord’s real attitude to the matter, when he writes: ‘I hate divorce, says the Lord’ (Mal. 2:16). The Old Testament is thus not significantly against the New, where Jesus himself speaks strongly against divorce (though not without leaving a loophole for the offended party, Matt. 19:3-9), and where Paul commands that believers should remain with their unbelieving spouses... (1 Cor. 7:10-16). This seems to place Ezra well out on a limb” (69).

In this appendix, I will briefly survey and respond to the approaches of a sample of commentators

the people’s submission to Him as their Lord, whether in relative health they brought their sacrifices of praise or, falling into spiritual ill health, brought their prayers of repentance. The temple bore witness to God’s power and to His restoring love.”

¹⁰² Speaking of the return under Cyrus, Oren (103) says, “This restoration was a sign of God’s faithfulness to his promise. But this (partial) fulfillment of God’s promised restoration in no way compares to the prophets’ final vision, for the returning remnant was far from the holiness that the Lord promised would come with the age of the Spirit.”

¹⁰³ Some corollaries can be drawn here: I do not think that in the next life men will have any need at all to exercise the kind of leadership that some men are called (as I believe) to exercise in the home and the church, yet in the meantime such leadership is God-ordained; similarly, spiritual gifts will not be needed in the next life, yet (as I read it) Paul calls for their (careful) use until that time.

¹⁰⁴ Cf. Appendix 3 above.

¹⁰⁵ Levering (20): “The time of Ezra and Nehemiah was one of intense striving toward the promised covenantal fulfillment of holy people and holy land. When this fulfillment comes in Jesus, it is not a negation or displacement of the striving recorded in these two books. Jesus could not have symbolically acted out the fulfillment of Israel had there no longer been the Torah to read or the temple in which to celebrate the festivals.”

to this difficult passage.¹⁰⁶

There is much of importance in Levering's words: "The preservation of distinctiveness is crucial [not only for OT Israel but] also for the economy in Christ. The first Christians are 'aliens and exiles' who must 'abstain from the passions of the flesh that wage war against your soul' (1 Pet. 2:11). Christians must keep free from those who 'entice with licentious passions of the flesh men who have barely escaped from those who live in error' (2 Pet. 2:18)... Only after a plague has killed twenty-four thousand Israelites does the priest Phineas's action spare the people of Israel. King Solomon, supremely wise due to God's gift, becomes in old age supremely foolish due to his many marriages with non-Israelite women. After Israel's conquest of the land, Joshua had urged... 'For if you turn back, and join the remnant of these nations left here among you, and make marriages with them, so that you marry their women and they yours, know assuredly that the LORD your God will not continue to drive out these nations before you; but they shall be a snare and a trap for you... till you perish from off this good land which the LORD your God has given you' (23:12-13). What Joshua warns against, of course, later happens. Ezra is trying to ensure that it does not happen again" (98). Levering goes on to argue (98-99) that the purity of the messianic line—who according to prophecy had to be a physical descendant of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob—was at risk. This last point is perhaps a bit wide of the mark in that Jesus Christ does in fact have several gentiles in his lineage, his davidic descent nevertheless remaining intact (Mat 1:1-17). Moreover, the individuals discussed in these chapters of EN do not seem to make any specifically messianic connections, thinking instead of the (im)purity of the people as a whole and its (un)worthiness to have the privilege of dwelling in the land (E 9:10-15).

In light of this last observation, this observation of Thomas' bears consideration: "these were highly unusual circumstances involving the purity of a highly unusual race of people—the covenant people of God" (184). Roberts seems to reason very similarly, both as to the danger involved (142) and as to the uncertainty as to the best solution to those circumstances (153). Petter and Petter think that the mass divorce was clearly justified in its day (246-247); Ulrich seems to agree, though reticent about how the text might apply today (93-96). Breneman views this as a "historically unique case" (164), and he urges caution about generalizations (165); cf. Ryken and Ryken (this is "a onetime event," 648) and Fyall (130-136). McConville's thoughts are certainly along these lines (70-71), as are Fensham's (140), Harrington's (262-263), and Kidner's (80-81). Steinmann is emphatic, and argues that "the First Commandment (Ex 20:3; Deut 5:7) takes precedence over all other commands" (359). Larson and Dahlen put the matter like this: "The decision stands in marked contrast to the teachings of the New Testament. Jesus clearly prohibited divorce except in instances of immorality (Matt. 5:32); Paul, within the framework of certain concessions, instructed Christians to refrain from divorce, even if married to an unbeliever (1 Cor. 7:12-17). However, to Ezra and the other leaders, the survival of the Jewish faith and community seemed at risk. Drastic measures were needed to purify the community from a growing corruption" (119). All this probably gets quite close to describing the Judean leaders' thoughts at the time. But—to evaluate that line of thinking in the light of Scripture as a whole—the ends do not justify the means (Thomas, 190), and Thomas is in my view right to express doubt (on the same page) about the compatibility of this line of thinking with what Scripture elsewhere teaches about divorce.

Thomas, for his part (189), seems to prefer a different approach: he suggests that the verb (נשא) does not mean "marry" in this passage, and that other ambiguities in the Hebrew can be taken together to suggest that the women in question never married the men in question (183-184). In this case, the community is not implementing a mass divorce, only a mass cessation of cohabitation. But the sense of "marry" for נשא in late Hebrew is well established in my view (cf. Hurvitz, 185-187), and it seems to me that the situation would have unfolded differently if extramarital sexuality was the real issue (cf. Lev 20:10).

As noted above, Breneman views the circumstances in Ezra 9-10 as unique, but he also feels that

¹⁰⁶ I will mention here two books which are not commentaries but which devote significant space to the topic of divorce: Adams writes that God's revulsion for the effects of (justified or unjustified) divorce "did not stop Him from willing divorce in Ezra 10:44, 11" (24); Murray does not cite the book of EN at all.

because of the paganism involved, the “marriages were wrong from the outset” (164; similarly, but more tentatively, see Fyall, 135). Larson and Dahlen develop this point a bit more: “The law [E 10:4], in this case, may refer to the concessions of Deuteronomy 24:1-4 in which a man could divorce his wife if he found ‘something indecent about her.’ Since the foreign women were now deemed ‘unclean,’ a formal divorce would then be ‘lawful.’ Shecaniah might, however, simply have meant that the people should proceed according to the spirit of the law that prohibited marriage outside the faith” (117). Hamilton does not seem to spell out how to reconcile Ezra 9-10 with other divorce-related passages of the Bible, but he probably can be described as taking a similar view, for he compares the pagan Canaanite women to putrid, murderous monsters (81-82). He adds that he “assumes[s] that the foreign women willing to identify with Israel and worship Yahweh would not be put away” (91). It bears repeating that even if in OT times worship of gods other than Yahweh justified divorce, the situation is altogether different nowadays: Christians are not to initiate divorce from an unbelieving spouse, though they must accept it if their spouse abandons them because of their religion (1 Cor 7:12-16). In fact, that same passage indicates that there is a sense in which an unbelieving spouse and children of such a mixed marriage are “holy”—merely being married to or being a child of a believer does not make one a part of God’s people, but neither are such people to be thought of as monsters. Hamilton might be thinking only of the sins that these women would commit, not the individuals as such, but in any case I doubt that mandating divorce has a firm basis even in the OT. Polygamy stands as God’s intent from the beginning (Gen 2:24 says “wife,” not “wives,” and the logic of “become one flesh” is only fully sustainable with two persons are involved), yet Ex 21:10 does not call for divorce when polygamy occurs, but only regulates it so as to minimize abuses.

MacArthur puts my position into a few words: “We must remember... that Ezra is a book of history and records actual historical events. The fact that a person did something in Israel’s history does not mean it is a model of God’s ideal plan for us to follow, for God hates divorce (see Malachi 2:16)” (79).¹⁰⁷ Others at least entertain this possibility (Roberts, 152; Thomas, 189). Shepherd and Wright—while acknowledging that the mass divorce is the brainchild of “Shecaniah, son of Jehiel (Ezra 10:2)” not “a prophet speaking on behalf of God,” and agreeing with an assessment that the Pentateuch has been poorly used in this case (148)—assert that “the overall feel of the passage is that the narrator approves of this action” (149). But the narrator, who does occasionally speak to God’s role in events (e.g., E 5:5), does not signal either approval or disapproval from the throne of heaven, so this is only speculation. In fact, in his article Lubeck goes further, arguing at length that the author of EN has shaped the narrative to imply that this whole effort was wrong-headed and self-defeating. Lubeck is correct to some degree in stating that “however well-intentioned, leaders cannot precipitate inward change by prescribing outward measures” (184). At the least, great caution should be exercised before assuming that some action, even if done by a man of character, meets God’s approval.

Appendix 7: Christ and Ezra-Nehemiah

There are many parallels between the lives of Ezra and Nehemiah and the life of Jesus—some coincidental at some level, but some surely not. For all of Scripture points to Christ, and EN, too, sets up patterns and creates expectations that will be elevated and fulfilled in Christ. On the links between Ezra and Jesus, Hamilton says this (239): “Ezra was a man of the Word and prayer who was passionate for the purity of God’s people, seeking to hallow God’s name, to bring in God’s kingdom, and to do God’s will on earth as in heaven... Ezra responded to the disobedience and rebellion of God’s people by weeping over Jerusalem, but as Jesus would weep over Jerusalem’s refusal to receive and welcome him... Ezra was also

¹⁰⁷ However, elsewhere MacArthur seems to evidence a different train of thought. In the introduction to Ezra, he says that it “seems to have been decided that the lesser wrong of divorce would be preferable to the greater wrong of the Jewish race being polluted by intermarriage so that the messianic line of David would not be ended by being mingled with Gentiles. To solve this problem this way magnifies the mercy of God, in that the only other solution would have been to kill all those involved” (viii). Whether MacArthur is stating his own mind or is describing Shecaniah’s is unclear to me. Either way, I doubt that Shecaniah or anyone else was thinking in terms of lesser vs. greater evils, or that the davidic line *per se* was uppermost in their minds at this point.

a priest and scribe devoted to the law of Moses. Jesus came as the high priest according to the order of Melchizedek, and He countered temptation and those who challenged him in debate with appeals to Scripture.” To this it can be added that as Ezra ministered in accordance with the old covenant, Jesus ministered in a greater way, fulfilling the old and inaugurating the new covenant.

Concerning Nehemiah and Jesus, Hamilton observes (239-140): “Nehemiah cleanse[d] the temple... Nehemiah was also concerned for the resumption of the worship instituted by David [cf. Jn 4:21-24]. Nehemiah initiated a renewal of the covenant, anticipating the One who would usher God’s people into a new covenant... Nehemiah typified Jesus as one who wept over Jerusalem (Neh. 1:4). Just as Jesus would call His disciples to come, follow him, and build God’s kingdom through the church, Nehemiah called the people of God to rise and build with him (Neh. 2:18). The nations rage against the Lord and His Anointed One, as Psalm 2:1-3 describes (cf. Acts 4:25-28), and they raged against Nehemiah too (Neh. 4:1-3,7). Just as plots were made against Jesus, there was a plot to ambush Nehemiah (6:2). Just as there was a politically incendiary statement made against Jesus, “we have no king but Caesar,” there was a politically incendiary charge against Nehemiah’s intentions in rebuild[ing] the wall (6:6).” Full agreement may or may not be registered regarding Hamilton’s words about the kingdom of God here, but in general the case is compelling. Furthermore, Nehemiah’s leaving of the king’s palace to be with his troubled people, his constant turning to God in prayer, his discretion (cf. 2:11 with Mat 16:20, etc.), his refusal to claim comforts for himself (cf. 5:18 with Mat 8:20, 20:28), and his anger at injustice (cf. 5:1ff with Mk 12:38-40), further underscore the point.¹⁰⁸ Ezra and Nehemiah, for all their imperfections, help in their ways to craft expectations for and give hints about the greater work of Christ to come.

Probably more important than connections between Ezra and Nehemiah as individuals and Christ, however, is the larger trajectory in which the book of EN stands. McConville states it well: “Without in any sense diminishing the greatness of the deliverance from Babylon or its demonstration of God’s commitment to Judah, there is nevertheless a strong feeling throughout our books that the full potential for a relationship between God and his people has not yet been realized. This is related, no doubt, to the fact that the community, *though* chastened, falls again and yet again into sin (see on Ezra 9-10). The events that occur under Zerubbabel, Ezra and Nehemiah are not God’s last word. The ‘restoration’ is nothing in itself, but in terms of a wider biblical theology—merely a necessary setting of the stage for a far greater act of God in which his search for human obedience within the covenant is finally gratified in the life of Jesus of Nazareth—at once himself God and, in his humanity, representative ‘Israel.’ It is this intermediate status of the post-exilic restoration which makes it possible for *Christians*—who have no interest in Jewish Temple, walls or nationhood *as such*—to take the Books of Ezra and Nehemiah profitably to themselves. Their real significance neither begins nor ends with bricks and mortar, but lies rather in the fact that God has acted again, and *will* act, on behalf of his people” (5). The work of the temple was never a finished task, but Jesus has completed the work of God, redeeming his people irrevocably (Heb 10:11-14).

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¹⁰⁸ These observations are culled from a longer list given to me in a personal communication from Stephen Bowne.

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